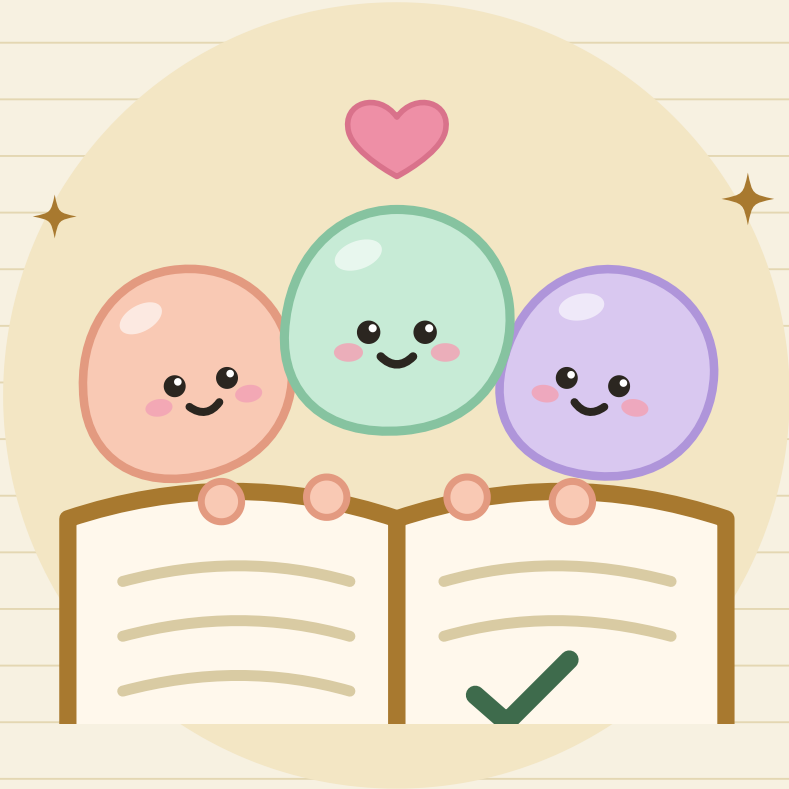
# Spread Love & Acceptance

*Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with*



**For two or more** · Short version

Part Two: sharing a home, work or care with the people around you.

*by Christian*

# Spread Love & Acceptance

FOR TWO OR MORE · SHORT VERSION

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*Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with*

FOR TWO OR MORE · SHORT VERSION



*by Christian*

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

*Spread Love & Acceptance*: For two or more, the short version.
By Christian. Published by Spread Love & Acceptance.

This edition: October 2026. Made from the chapters at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, where they are kept up to date.

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**Not therapy.** This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

**If you are not safe.** If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

**The examples are made up.** The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

# If you need help now

**If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number:** 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

| WHERE YOU ARE | CALL OR TEXT |
|---|---|
| **United States** | Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line). |
| **United Kingdom** | Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line). |
| **Ireland** | Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. |
| **Canada** | Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French. |
| **Australia** | Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14. |
| **New Zealand** | Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?). |
| **Anywhere else** | **findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat. |

## For children and young people

| | |
|---|---|
| **UK** | Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19) |
| **Ireland** | Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18) |
| **Canada** | Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868 |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Australia** | Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25) |
| **New Zealand** | Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234 |
| **US** | 988 is for every age. |

## If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12 (online) says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16 (online) about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

# How to use this book

*This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 6 chapters in one part, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.*

### THE PARTS

> **Part Two: Between us.** One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

### TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

### READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

### IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

### THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the workpapers (pages you fill in) and tools (helpers you use) that the chapters mention; the next page explains both. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

### GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

# Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **Workpapers: pages you fill in**

A workpaper is a page you fill in, on your own or together: a one-week log, a list of who owns which job, a short check. Each one has a number, like **WP-03**, and it is always called a workpaper, for example “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. The blank workpapers are also at the back of this book, one page each, to copy.

TOOL **Tools: helpers you use on the site**

A tool is an interactive helper on the website: a quiz, a calm-down timer, a card maker, or the Chat analyzer that reads a message with you. You use it and it gives you something back. It is always called a tool, for example “Tool: Chat analyzer”.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

## Three friends who give hints



**Professor Puddles**, the site’s cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints: a thought to take with you, and the workpaper or tool that fits.



**Tidbit**, the quick, curious pup with the big smile and the collar, bounds in now and then with a playful tip.



**Sugarfoot**, the steady, gentle pup with the long soft ears and the best hugs, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

# Find it fast

*Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.*

SHARING THE LOAD

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **We keep arguing about chores.** | Part Two · Chapter II · One owner per job | 45 | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |
| **I do the remembering and planning, and nobody sees it (the mental load).** | Preface to Part Two · The mental load | 27 | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what |
| **We each think we do more than our share.** | Preface to Part Two · Why the other person doesn't see it | 18 | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what |
| **The same job keeps slipping, week after week.** | Part Two · Chapter V · A repeat usually has no real owner | 96 | WORKPAPER WP-04 What keeps coming back? |
| **Is the way we share things fair? Can it last?** | Part Two · Chapter II · The setup score | 45 | TOOL Is the setup working for everyone? |
| **We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.** | Part Two · Chapter II · Small children and a new baby | 58 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **We're about to move in together.** | Part Two · Chapter V · Starting out: before you move in | 107 | TOOL The "Who does what?" page |
| **Money between us feels unfair.** | Part Two · Chapter IV · Money between you | 92 | TOOL Who does what? The Money tab |
| **We co-parent across two homes.** | Part Two · Chapter III · Two homes | 76 | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |
| **We share a house with a housemate, or more than two of us share a home.** | Part Two · Chapter IV · A couple and a housemate | 93 | TOOL The "Who does what?" page |

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I'm raising my grandchild (kinship care).** | Part Two · Chapter V · Raising a grandchild | 108 | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |
| **Faith matters to us, or family elders expect a say.** | Part Two · Chapter I · Faith, culture and family voices | 42 | WORKPAPER WP-13 The 90-second daily check-in |
| **I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.** | Part Two · Chapter III · When "full" has become normal | 64 | WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying? |
| **I'm the only one who wants to try this.** | Part Two · Chapter II · When only one of you is on board | 61 | WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what (your side only) |
| **Someone handed me this book, and I'm not sure why.** | If someone handed you this book | 11 | WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job |

## TALKING IT THROUGH

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Small things turn into big rows.** | Part Two · Chapter I · How stress changes your frequency | 32 | WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit |
| **We move and talk at different speeds.** | Part Two · Chapter I · What sets the frequency | 32 | WORKPAPER WP-12 Same moment, different speeds |
| **A comment stings and I snap back.** | Part Two · Chapter IV · Let a comment land before you react | 86 | WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands |
| **Is it us, or is it everything else going on?** | Part Two · Chapter III · Leftover stress | 64 | WORKPAPER WP-14 Is it us, or is it everything else? |

## HARD SEASONS

| IF THIS IS GOING ON | READ | PAGE | TRY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I'm thinking about ending my life, or I'm worried someone is.** | If you need help now | 5 | The page itself |

This copy holds only part of the book, so this map lists the problems it covers. The whole book's map has 16 more, and every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book. Each thing to try is marked as a workpaper (a page you fill in) or a tool (a helper you use on the site). All are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a code you can scan for them. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

# If someone handed you this book

*Maybe it was left on your side of the bed with a page turned down. Maybe someone said, "Could you just read this bit?" Either way, you didn't choose it. Fair enough. Here is the short version, written for you.*

## This isn't a case against you

The book starts from something researchers have found again and again: when two people each estimate their share of the housework, the two answers usually add up to more than 100%. Nobody is lying. You see every minute of your own effort and only some of theirs, and so do they (Chapter II, page **45**). So the book never asks who the bad guy is. Its numbers score the setup, never a person.

## What's in it for you

- Fewer repeat arguments about the same jobs.
- Jobs that are clearly yours, so nobody needs to remind you about them.
- Credit for what you already do. Your jobs go on the list too: the car, the bins, the late-night lifts, the things you fix.
- A say in what "fair" means in your house. It isn't always 50/50 (Chapter IV, page **79**).

It doesn't ask for therapy talk, and you never fill anything in about the other person. You can say no.

## A first week: three small things

1. **Log your own week.** Rough minutes on "Who did what", including the thinking part: booking, remembering, planning. Ten minutes in all. Only yours, never theirs.
2. **Ask one question, and just listen.** "What's the one job you'd most like to stop thinking about?" Don't defend or count. Write the answer down.
3. **Take over that job, the whole of it,** including the noticing (below).

### Words to open the talk

> "I read the bit you gave me. I don't agree with all of it, but I get the point about the stuff nobody sees."
> "I'd rather own a couple of things properly than 'help' with everything. Which one would you most like off your mind?"
> "Give me a week to see what I actually do. Then let's look together."

**Best left out, for now:** "Just tell me what to do" (it hands the thinking straight back), "You should have asked" and, in the first five minutes, "I do loads too." That may be true. Save it for when you both have your logs.

### Taking over a whole job, noticing included

Every job has a part you can see (doing it) and parts you can't: noticing it needs doing, remembering, planning and checking it got done (the Preface, page **18**). Taking a job over means all of it.

1. **Pick one job that repeats:** the children's clothes and shoes, the bins, the car, school forms, the dentist.
2. **Get the handover once.** What it involves, when it's due, where things are, who to call. Ask your questions now, not every week.
3. **Move the remembering out of their head.** A phone reminder, the calendar, a list on the fridge: anywhere but the other person.
4. **Do it start to finish for a month** without being reminded. If you need reminding, fix your reminder, not the relationship.
5. **Do it your way.** If the result is fine, the method is yours. Their part is to let it be done differently.
6. **Ask for a backstop if you like:** someone who notices a slip and says so once, kindly. A backstop isn't a supervisor (Chapter II, page **45**).

**A made-up example.** Hester has always looked after the children's clothes: spotting toes at the end of shoes, school sizes, swimming kit, passing on what's outgrown. Wilf takes it over. Hester writes the handover note: sizes, the shop, which drawer holds the next size up. Wilf sets a reminder for the first Sunday of each month: "Shoes, uniform, kit." In week two he misses the PE kit for a school trip. Hester says once, "The trip kit is Thursday," and he adds "school letters" to his Sunday check. A month in, Hester says the biggest change is that she no longer thinks about shoes at eleven at night.

## If you think it's already fair

Log your week anyway. If it comes out even, that is useful to know, and the book will say so: a fair score doesn't silence anyone, and a low one doesn't blame anyone. And if this book feels like the wrong place to start, Find it fast, page 9 lists other ways in.

# The book in two pictures

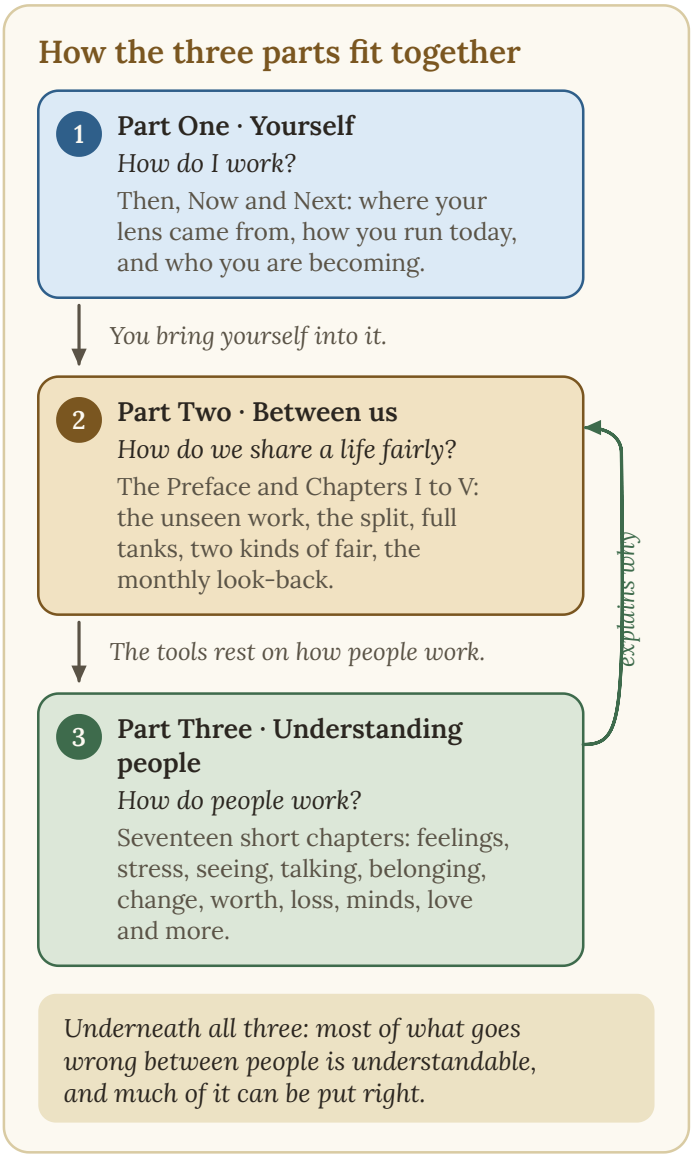



FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

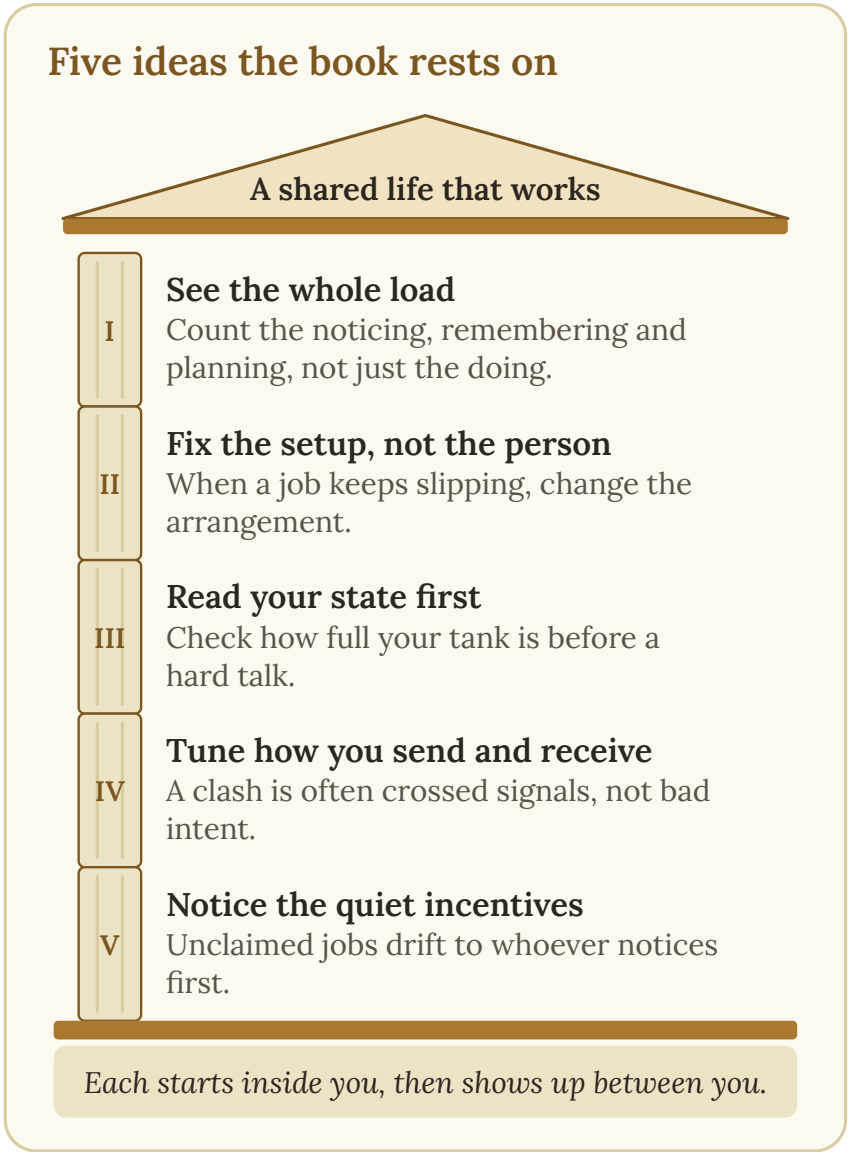



FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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PART TWO

# Between us

*One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.*

IN THIS PART


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Preface | The work nobody sees | 18 |
| Chapter I | Why we get out of tune | 32 |
| Chapter II | Is the split working? | 45 |
| Chapter III | Full tanks and different angles | 64 |
| Chapter IV | Two kinds of fair | 79 |
| Chapter V | The monthly look-back | 96 |




TIDBIT

This part comes with workpapers to fill in, together or on your own. If you only try one, make it the one-week log.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

# Preface

PREFACE TO PART TWO

## The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home

*Part Two of the book is about the people you share a life or a home with, and it opens here. Running a life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This preface helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so you can talk about it fairly and kindly.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. On your own: your own unseen work
11. One household, followed for a month
12. Your situation, chapter by chapter
13. Common mix-ups
14. Limits and cautions


IN SHORT

- **Running a home takes unseen work**, the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature, and missing it says little about how much someone cares.
- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- **The list is for seeing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

*The washing has been in the machine since Saturday morning and will need doing again, because it has that smell. The school trip form is due Tuesday. The birthday card for Auntie Jean is on the hall table, still in its cellophane, unsigned. Somebody in the house has noticed all three of these things, and it is probably you.*

*Somebody has also noticed that nobody else has noticed. From the hallway the house looks fine, which is exactly the trouble.*

***Kin work***

*The anthropologist Micaela di Leonardo called the cards, calls, visits and presents that keep a wider family connected "kin work". In the families she studied it was done mostly by women and treated as if it took no effort at all. The unsigned card on the hall table is a small piece of it.*

**di Leonardo (1987)** · *Moderate: an influential qualitative study*

01

## Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing the milk is low, calming a tense moment before it turns into a row. None of it shows up on a calendar, so it rarely gets a thank-you, and over months it piles up. This book calls the pile *unbilled debt*, because nobody ever sends a bill for it. (It's a ledger word, and I make no apology for it. I spent my career as a government auditor, where a control is just an agreement about how a thing gets done, who owns it and how anyone would notice if it stopped. Who notices that the milk is low is a control in your home too, and if it only works because the same person quietly catches it every time, it was never really set up.) You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled.

Marcus remembers every school form, every dentist appointment and every bit of lunch money for their two children. His husband, Theo, sees two children who always seem to have what they need, PE kit included, and genuinely has no idea how. When Marcus went to Glasgow for three days in March, Theo found out. Both children went to school on non-uniform day in uniform, and one of them went without a coat. Theo rang Marcus on the

second night and said, “How do you *know*?” He isn’t careless, and never was; the work had simply been out of his sight for eleven years.

**The second shift**

Arlie Hochschild’s interviews and home visits with working couples found mothers doing far more of the housework and childcare, a second shift on top of the paid one, and many couples telling themselves a story in which the split was fair. Large time-use surveys since show the gap persisting, and narrowing.

**Hochschild with Machung (1989)** · *Moderate: an influential qualitative study; its figures describe its own sample*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Write down one ordinary week. Only your own jobs, and the thinking counts too. Most people are surprised by their own list.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

02

## A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check that it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy, though nobody can see it. In a shared flat above a launderette, Yasmin noticed the broadband deal ended in three weeks. She compared six plans on a spreadsheet, picked one, set it up, and checked the next morning that it had gone through. Paying took two minutes, while the thinking took most of a Thursday evening, and as far as she knows nobody else in the flat has any idea it happened. When the internet kept working, one of them said, “Oh good, the broadband’s fine.”

**Four parts of the thinking**

Interviewing 35 couples, Allison Daminger split household thinking work into anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding and monitoring. Women in the study did more of it overall, especially the anticipating and the monitoring, deciding was shared more equally, and much of it went unseen by both partners.

**Daminger (2019)** · *Moderate: a rich interview study of mostly college-educated couples; not population figures*

Pick one job at home and split it into its steps (noticing, planning, doing, checking), then ask who usually does each one.

## The work nobody sees

*Most of a job happens before and after the doing.*

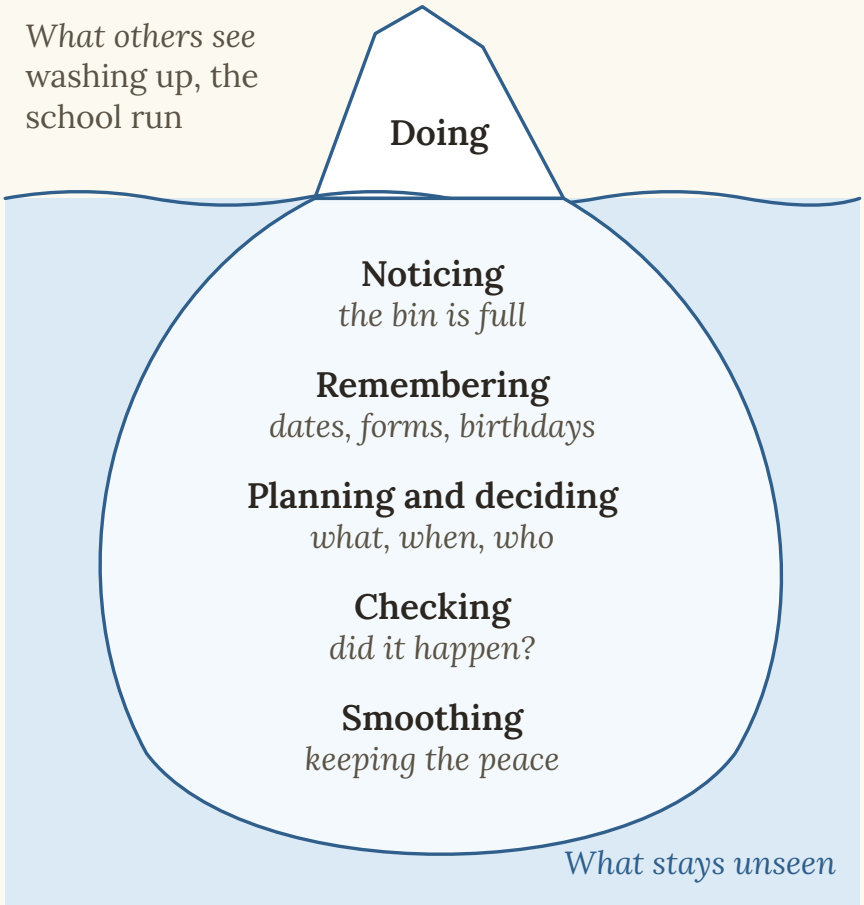



*Illustration. The five kinds are this book's plain words; researchers call the thinking part "cognitive labour" (Daminger, 2019).*

FIGURE 3 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

## The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen, so the other person is rarely ignoring it. From where they stand, things look as though they take care of themselves. Edna minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own hospital appointments to fit, and her daughter thinks it all slots in easily. It doesn't. Edna has cancelled her eye clinic twice. A gentle question often opens it up ("What's something you do that you think I don't see?"), followed by listening without explaining.

Sometimes it only becomes visible when the person who carried it has gone. Over his first winter alone, a widower found out how many jobs his wife had quietly held, from the birthday cards and the boiler service to knowing who to ring when someone was ill. He didn't see any of it until it stopped getting done, and the boiler broke in January. If that's where you are, the section for people on their own, further on in this chapter, was written with you in mind.

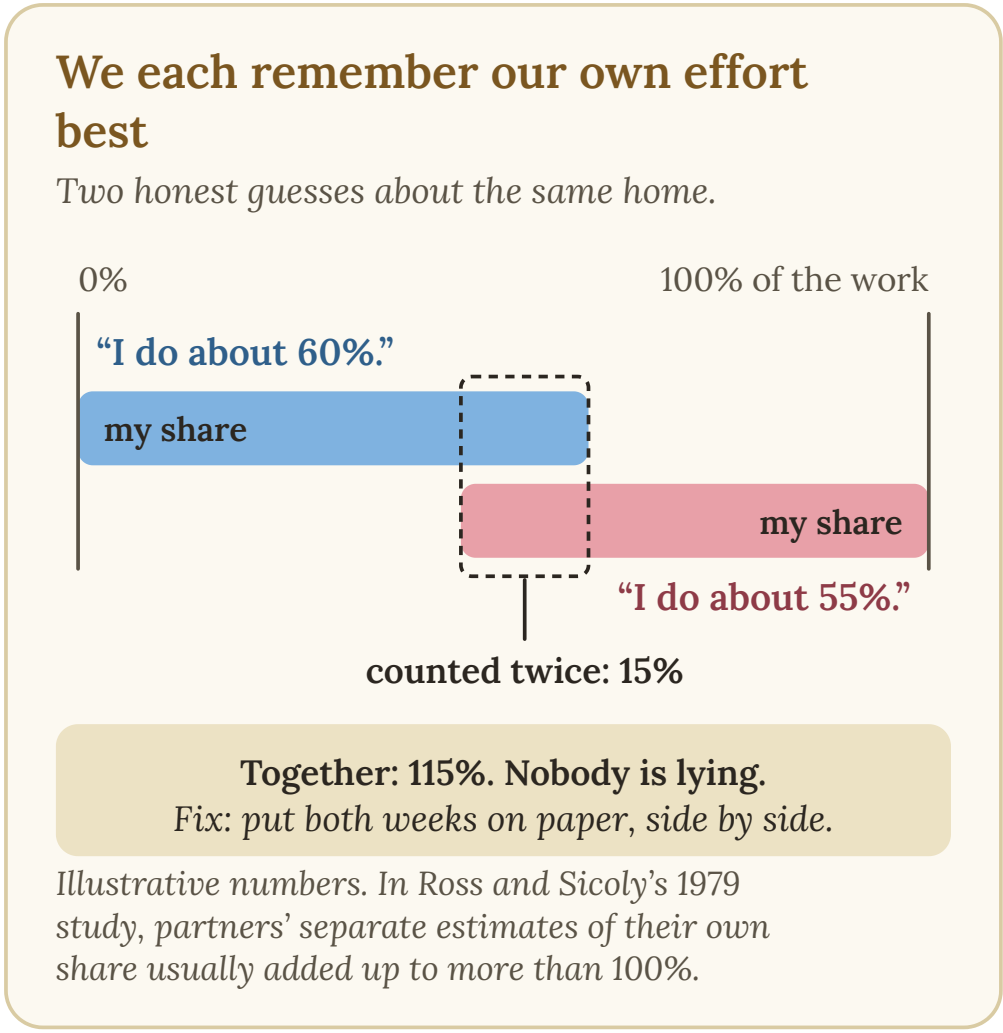



FIGURE 4 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers; in Ross and Sicoly's 1979 study, partners' estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

## Writing it down isn't keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time, so the talk starts from facts you share. This book calls that shared record a *ledger*, a plain list of who did what, kept for seeing.

Two colleagues who job-share each listed a week of tasks. It turned out every single difficult client call had landed on Tamsin, every one of them, and nobody had decided that. It had just happened, the way these things do,

because she was better at them. They left last year alone and agreed to take turns with Friday calls. A quick look at who does what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand) is a gentle place to start. Before you show anyone a list, ask yourself honestly whether it's to plan next week or to prove a point. If it's the second, keep it in the drawer for now.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

**Who did what**

*Marcus and Theo, a couple*

## Who did what

Person A
*Marcus*

Person B
*Theo*

Week beginning
5 October 2026

### Part A: Who did what, this week

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Mon* | *Plan the week's meals* | *Theo* | 20 | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Mon* | *Cook dinner* | *Marcus* | 45 | *Asked for* |
| *Tue* | *Book the boiler service* | *Theo* | 15 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Tue* | *Dishes* | *Marcus* | 20 | *Asked for* |
| *Wed* | *Laundry, wash to put away* | *Theo* | 60 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Thu* | *Remember Marcus's mum's birthday card* | *Theo* | 10 | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Fri* | *Bins and recycling out* | *Marcus* | 10 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sat* | *Big food shop* | *Both* | 70 | *Asked for* |

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

**Marcus**
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

**Theo**
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

**Workload balance score**
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

**Unasked-for work**
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

**Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no**

Left blank this week.

*Made-up example.*

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

05

## Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did and then read the two lists together, which keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, a long week at work, children off school with colds, so you both understand what you read.

Arran, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a rented house in Leith. Each wrote only their own list, in their own handwriting, which in Dani's case needed some translating. Reading them together at the kitchen table, Sol learned for the first time that Arran had rung the landlord about the damp every single month since February. "Every month?" said Sol. "Every month,"

said Arran. Dani said, “I thought it had just stopped.” It hadn’t; it had spread behind the wardrobe.

06

## The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what is happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here.

Two brothers share their mum’s care, and one of them had been about to say “You never help” for about a year. What he said in the end was “There’s some work here neither of us has looked at properly.” His brother, braced for a row, found he didn’t need to have one. If words like “ledger” or “debt” feel heavy, use your own. “Our list” and “the stuff nobody sees” do the same job.

07

## One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool, and one week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying that day, and a monthly look-back that needs only a few lines a week. Precious is a nurse on nights and her partner works days, and they hardly see each other awake. They started with one week of notes stuck to the fridge with a magnet from Whitby, and changed nothing at all for a week. That was the whole plan. Your first step can be as small as picking a start day and setting one reminder.



TIDBIT

Counting jobs isn’t keeping score. It’s looking for the work nobody noticed, and the quick split check is a good place to start.

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

08

## It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, families, housemates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, and the ideas fit anyone who shares a load. In a foster home, the carer keeps track of family visits and

social worker calls, while a fifteen-year-old in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week, usually pasta, and both kinds of work deserve counting.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back towards your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

*"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly.*

*Someone did, though. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked as if it took care of itself, the way a house seems to clean itself if you're never in it on a Saturday morning. You don't say this. You say "It's fine," which it isn't, quite.*

## The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**, meaning the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done and the checking after. It includes knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes, and remembering the form and the party present. It is real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby a gap often opens, and in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to, which researchers call *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in and lets them do it their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, and they say nothing certain about yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women, which is why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper instead of guessing.

Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter II (page 58).

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of, whole jobs, start to finish." Or the other way round, "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

## On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing it. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember (the appointments, the smoothing-over) and write them down for yourself. Count it without charging for it. The point is to see your real load so you can plan your energy. Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which just landed on you, and pick one you could hand back or do less often.

Nicola has the children every other week. Four years after the divorce, she sat down with a pen and found she was still buying the birthday presents for both sides of the family. His mum, his sister's twins and his godson in Cardiff were all still on her list. She handed his side back in one friendly message, and braced herself. He replied with a thumbs-up and, to her surprise, "fair enough". More for people living alone or after a breakup is on On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## One household, followed for a month

Three grown-up siblings share the care of their dad, who lives on his own in the house they grew up in. On paper the visits are split evenly, two days each. When each of them wrote a week of their own side, the picture changed. Ffion, the eldest, also held the prescriptions, the hospital letters and the calls to the GP, none of which counted as a visit. Their brother was surprised and a bit defensive, and the first conversation ended early, with someone leaving to "check the car". A month later they tried again. He took over the prescriptions completely, with the reminders on his own phone. Their sister still finds the hospital letters too much to face, so Ffion keeps those for now, and they've agreed to look again in the spring. Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) has a page for many other kinds of shared life.

## Your situation, chapter by chapter

Some situations get their own section:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws.** Chapter I (page 42)
- **Small children or a new baby.** Chapter II (page 58)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents.** Chapter III (page 76)
- **Money between you, and a couple with a housemate.** Chapter IV (page 92)
- **New together, or grandparents raising a grandchild.** Chapter V (page 107)

## Common mix-ups

"If it mattered, they'd have asked for help" misses how hidden this work is, often from the person doing it, until it's written down. Nobody needs exactly 50/50, either. What you're after is a split you can both see and both agree to. Please don't start by going over the last ten years. Start with one ordinary week, and thank each other for the past without trying to settle it. And the one doing less usually isn't the one who cares less. Usually they just can't see it yet, and once you've both seen it, what happens next is a choice you make together.

To start, each of you can list the things you did this week that nobody saw, then swap lists and read the other one slowly. Say one thing on it you hadn't noticed. Pick one item and thank them for it in a specific way. If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a coffee with the same questions works too. Fixing comes later. Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01) turns this into a gentle week-long log, and How to say a specific thank-you (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward) has more ideas.

## Limits and cautions

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A list should never be demanded, checked over your shoulder, or used to keep track of where you go or what you spend. If that is happening, it isn't a ledger. It's control, and it's not your fault. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs). If you are a counsellor or group leader using this book with others, see For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors).

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?**
*Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust* page 45

**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other**
*Why each person sees their own work first* read online

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well**
*Care work and how not to burn out* read online

**Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair**
*What fair means to each of you, before you talk* page 79

PUT IT TO USE



**Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



**Who did what**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01

# I

PART TWO · CHAPTER I

# Why we get out of tune: communication at home

*Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. On your own: your side of the tuning
11. One example, followed through
12. Common mix-ups


IN SHORT

- **A clash is often about how things were said.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Say that you are out of tune, pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence** that says what happened, how you feel and what you would like.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

*"I said I'd do it."*

*"I know. I'm just asking when."*

*"Why does it matter when?"*

*"It doesn't, I just…"*

*Four sentences later nobody is talking about the bins. Somebody has brought up last Christmas. Neither of you could point to the moment it turned.*

The radio picture in this chapter is my own. When two people who care about each other keep missing, what's usually lacking is timing and a shared way of putting things, and this chapter is an attempt at the shared way.

01

## The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something perfectly reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. Think of two radios slightly out of tune with each other. Together they make a crackle neither of them was making on its own.

"Is anyone using the oven tonight?" Lisa asked. Simple question. She had a lasagne in mind. Her housemate went pink and said, "Why, did I leave a mess?", and there was a pause in which the baking tray from Sunday, still soaking, became the only thing in the room. "I meant the lasagne," Lisa said eventually. "I know," said the housemate, who hadn't known, and went and washed the tray.

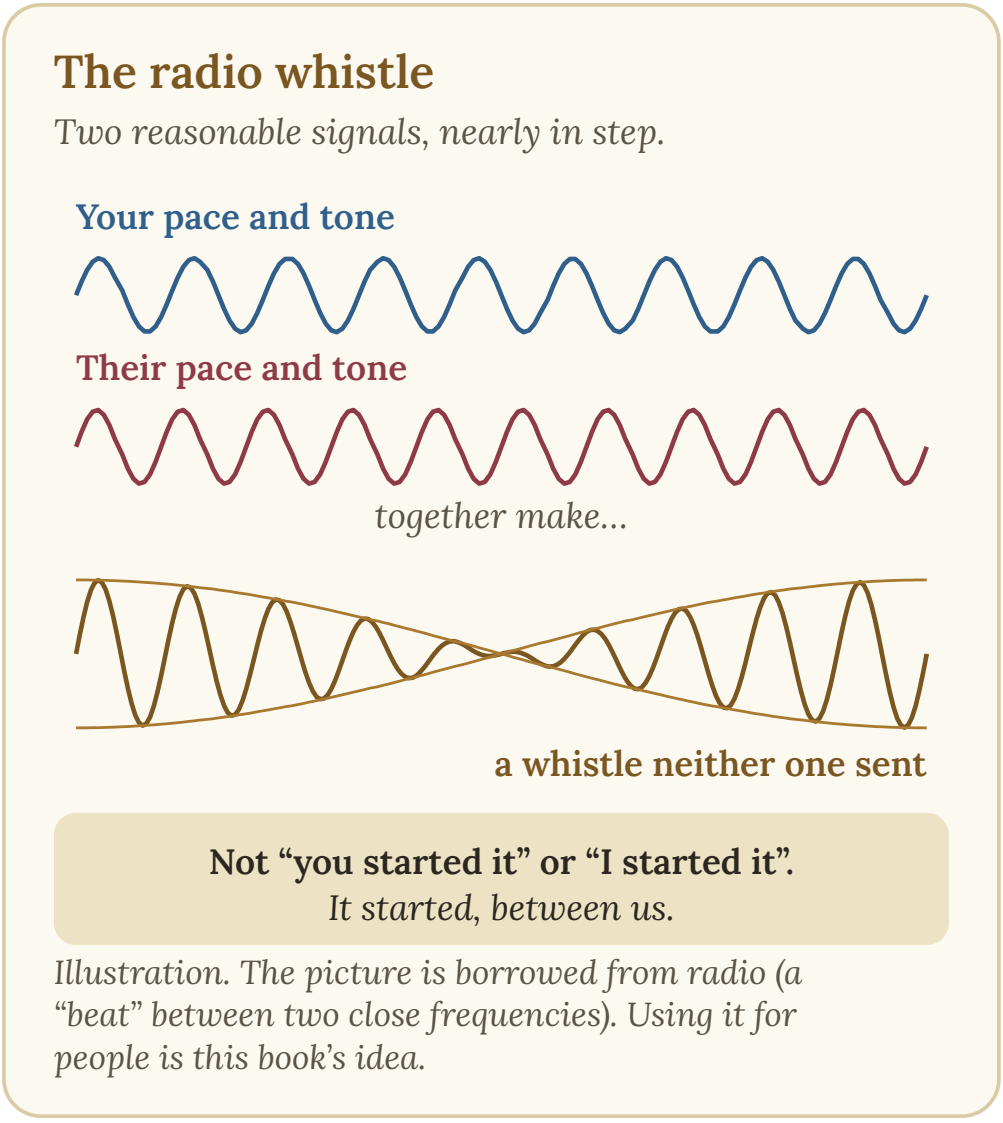



FIGURE 5 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

## Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on completely different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they’re close but not quite matched, which is why people who know each other well still clash. Research suggests we check our

meaning less with people we're close to, because we assume they already understand.

Two sisters who are on the phone every single day argue about holiday plans far more than either of them ever does with the cousins they see once a year, at christenings and funerals. The cousins get things spelled out. The sisters get shorthand, half a sentence, "you know what I mean". Quite often they don't.

With someone close to you, check one meaning today. "Just so I've got this right, you mean…?" It feels a bit formal, which is rather the point.



TIDBIT

Compare your daily rhythms: whose engine runs fast in the morning, and whose at night? Different speeds aren't wrong, they're just different.

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

03

## Three things knock you out of tune.

Pace is one, and tone is another, as when a plain update lands as a complaint. The third is urgency, since "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and some time before Easter to another. Texts lose most of their tone, so urgency is especially easy to misread there.

**We think our tone travels**

Across five experiments, people writing emails overestimated how well readers would pick up their tone, sarcasm or seriousness, largely because they couldn't hear their own message without their own voice in it.

**Kruger, Epley, Parker and Ng (2005)** · *Strong: several experiments, widely cited*

Between meetings, Vikram texted his business partner two words. *Need to talk.* She read it as a crisis and lay awake until two in the morning running through every disaster available, including the bank, the landlord and a client she'd always slightly distrusted. At nine he rang. It was about the printer. She has since asked him, politely and also not entirely politely, to add a time and the word "printer".

WAYS TO SAY IT

“By when would be good?” “Is this an update, or a worry?”

04

## Stress changes your station.

When you’re tense you may talk faster and hear a pause as a snub. When you’re tired and flat your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, gives you a best guess at which state you’re in. People’s ordinary rhythms differ too, before stress even arrives, and Rhythms side by side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration) lets you compare whose engine runs fast in the morning and whose at night.

Barry comes in off a night shift at the depot and his son asks him about Saturday. He gets “Fine” and “Yep” and “Later.” His son decides, on the spot, that his dad doesn’t care about Saturday or, by extension, him. Barry is simply running on empty after ten hours of forklifts and a forty-minute drive home with the window down to stay awake. He’d have told you so if he’d had any words left. He went to bed.

05

## Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work perfectly will still crackle if they’re slightly off, and arguing about whose fault the static is won’t clear it. Retuning will, which just means getting back in step.

On the doorstep, coat still on, Sylvia tells her grown-up son he looks tired. She means it as care. He hears “you’re not coping”, which is what he has been privately worrying about all week, and says “Thanks, Mum” in a voice that could strip paint. Both of them are right about what they meant and what they heard. That’s exactly why arguing about it goes nowhere. They manage to get through the visit, just, and both feel bad about it on the way home.

YOU COULD SAY

“I don’t think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?”

06

## Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say out loud that you think you're out of sync, and check how tense you are. Either of you can call a pause, and whoever pauses names a time to come back. Slow down, take shorter turns, and only then go back to the actual topic.

Two students sharing a room in halls agreed a pause word one calm Sunday. They picked "static", mainly because it made them laugh. Three weeks later, at one in the morning, in the middle of a row about someone's music, one of them said it, through gritted teeth. They stopped. Both lay there fuming in the dark. They came back to it at nine the next evening, as agreed, and sorted it out in ten minutes with headphones, a second set of headphones and a slightly sheepish packet of biscuits.

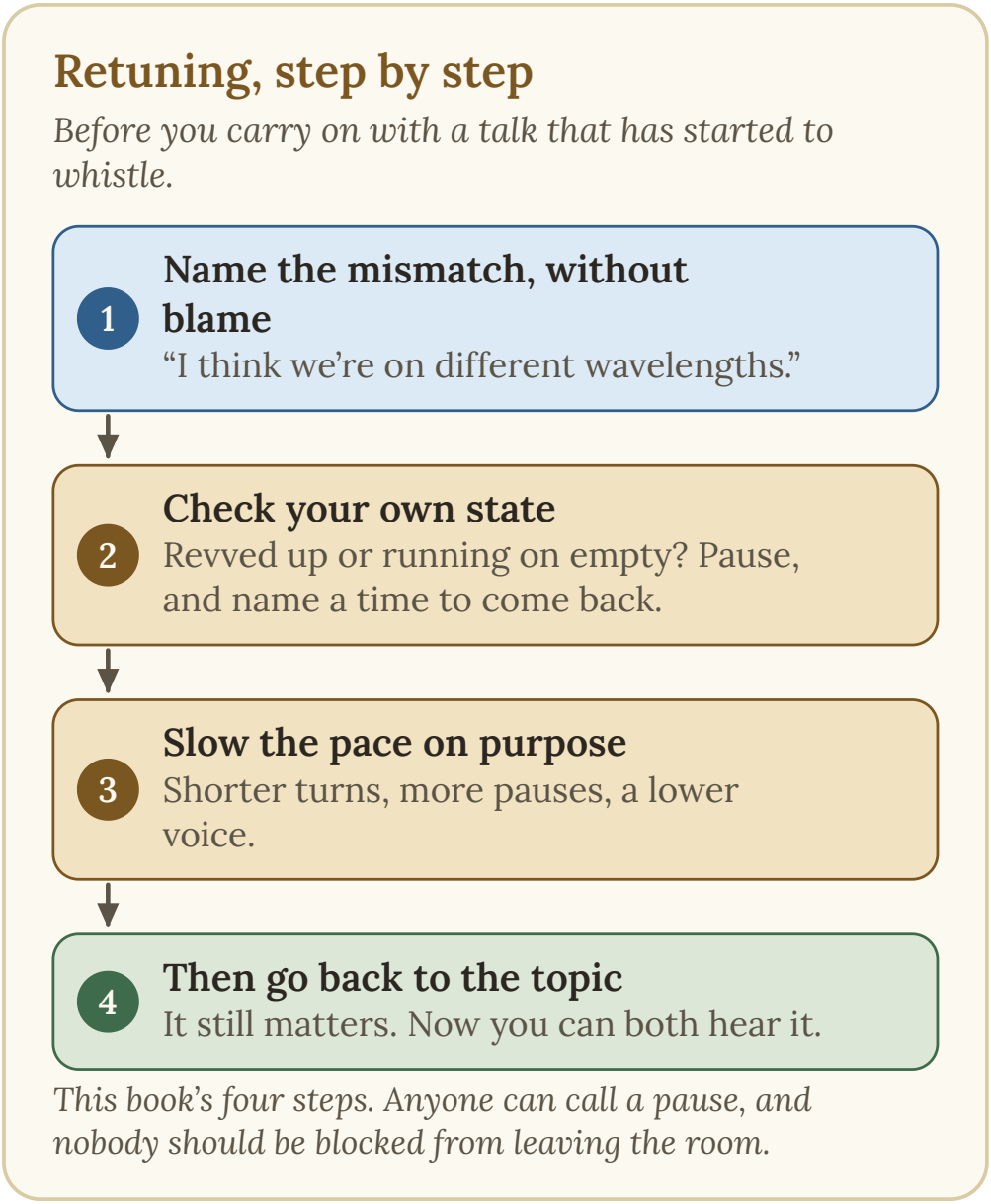



FIGURE 6 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

07

### Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you go back to the topic, say what happened, how you feel and what you'd like, in that order and in one go. "The bins go out early on Wednesday. I

get anxious when they're late. Could you put them out tonight?" Or, from one co-parent to the other, on a Sunday evening, "The swim kit wasn't in the bag and I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?" Write one about something small before you need it, so the shape is in your hand when you do.

**The first three minutes**

In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a disagreement went predicted which couples had divorced six years later. It's one lab's sample and not a crystal ball, but it's a good argument for opening gently.

**Carrère and Gottman (1999)** · *Moderate: one research group's sample; striking, not widely replicated as a predictor*



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you go back in, one clear sentence beats a speech. Write it down first. Speeches have a way of growing.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

08

## Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), makes tiny corrections before small things drift into a big row. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

Orla is in Leeds and Marc is in Toronto. Every morning each of them sends one 90-second voice note, usually something like "Bins went out, my boss is still weird, I miss you." On the weeks they forget, they notice it by Thursday, usually as an odd phone call about nothing in particular that leaves them both slightly put out.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was…"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

**The 90-second daily check-in**

*Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts*

## The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
*Priya*

Person B
*Dev*

Week beginning
5 October 2026

### Each day

| Day | Person | Stress tank | One thing I appreciated today | One small thing that didn't feel great | One thing that would help tomorrow |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Mon* | *Priya* | *High* | *You left soup in the fridge before my night shift* | *Woke up to the washing still in the machine* | *A text when you're leaving work* |
| *Mon* | *Dev* | *Medium* | *Your note on the kettle* | | *Bins out before I go at six* |
| *Tue* | *Priya* | *High* | *You kept the house quiet till noon* | | *Ten minutes together at the shift change* |
| *Tue* | *Dev* | *Light* | *You booked the car in* | *Missed you at dinner again* | |
| *Wed* | *Priya* | *Medium* | *Breakfast together at 8* | | *Early night* |
| *Wed* | *Dev* | *Medium* | *You remembered my mum's call* | | |

STRESS TANK THIS WEEK

**Priya**
2 high, 1 medium, 0 light

**Dev**
0 high, 2 medium, 1 light

### The weekly catch-up

| Sore spot that keeps coming up | Times this week | Move to |
|---|---|---|
| *Washing left in the machine* | 2 | *One owner per job* |
| *Missing each other at dinner* | 2 | *Keep watching* |

*Made-up example. One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.*

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 10AM

"*The spare room needs sorting at some point.*"

*She meant this month. He heard today, has already cancelled the football in his head and is quietly furious about it. By lunchtime you're both upset about a room nobody has touched. When you finally stop and ask each other what "at some point" meant, it turns out you still don't agree.*

## Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first, and a shared faith can be one of the strongest tools for staying in tune. Praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can serve as a daily check-in. Some couples each pray on their own before they come back to a hard talk, with the pause still ending at a named time. A pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to, and many can suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

Emeka and Ngozi, married twenty-six years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch, with the radio off. When a talk gets heated, either of them can say, "Let's pray on it and come back at eight," and at eight they do. Emeka says this works about nine times in ten. Ngozi says eight.

Culture shapes how you talk, too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom, and one habit helps a great deal. Each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives, once you've agreed the message together.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?" "Mum, we love you, and we've thought about it carefully. This year we'll visit in August instead of at Easter."

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

## On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace and your own sense of urgency, so you notice when you're the one running fast or slow. Learn your early signs of drifting. A clipped reply is a common one. So is a sudden urge to win. Learn how you take words in best and say it, once ("I hear things better in writing"). When you drift, step out, settle, come back. You don't need anyone's permission for that. Hamid lives alone and has noticed that his texts come out curt when he's tired, so he now

waits until morning to answer anything that matters (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## One example, followed through

Cerys, Marisol and Dougie share a house and a car. Cerys and Marisol talk fast, while Dougie talks slowly and thinks before he does it. At house meetings he kept getting talked over, and for a while the other two took his silence as agreement. It came out in March, when he said, quite mildly, that he had never actually agreed to the new car rota. Marisol said "Since when?" and Dougie said "Since always," and there was a long, uncomfortable pause. They tried a simple change, a round where each person speaks once before anyone answers. It felt stilted, and Cerys kept wanting to jump in and sat on her hands, literally. By the third meeting Dougie was saying more, and the rota he suggested is the one they use. Some evenings it still turns into two fast talkers and one quiet one, until somebody says "round" and they reset. Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) has pages for many other kinds of shared life.

## Common mix-ups

Retuning isn't giving in, because you still come back to the topic, at a time when you can hear each other. Being out of sync doesn't mean one of you is wrong, either. Two fair points in two different tones will still clash. And a pause never means the topic is dropped, since a pause comes with a time to come back, or it isn't a pause.

To try it, agree a shared phrase while things are calm ("I think we're out of tune" does fine) so that it works as a signal when you need it. For a week, each of you note one moment you felt out of step, and at the weekend compare whether it was mostly pace, tone or urgency. Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder), Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) and the 90-second daily check-in are free on the site.

**A limit to keep in mind:** These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking

things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

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THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works**
*How meaning, tone and listening work* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system**
*Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down* — read online

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words**
*How you like to be spoken to* — read online

**Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently**
*When pace and tone are a wiring difference* — read online

PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 1**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**The 90-second daily check-in**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in

# II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

# Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

*One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: is your own load working?
11. One setup, looked at twice
12. Common mix-ups
13. Small children and a new baby
14. If only one of you wants to try this
15. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **Look at the month, not last night**, using what you both wrote down.
- **Three things go in**, which are how the hours split, whether each job has a name, and how full each person's stress tank is.
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- **It judges the setup, never a person**, and it is where a talk starts.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

*One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about, like the bin rota and the fish food, the reply to the school, the dentist reminder, and the bit at the bottom of the shopping list that just says "bulbs?".*

*When the other one says it feels pretty even, they mean it. From inside their own week, it does.*

01

## Look at the month, not last night.

Ask whether the split is working and the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently, which is usually last night's pans. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Ask it again every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

Two housemates had one truly terrible week of dishes in May, the kind where you wash a fork in order to eat with it. They were all set for a big row. Then they looked at the whole month, written down, and it was three ordinary weeks and one exam week. The row didn't happen, which was almost a disappointment after all that build-up. They bought paper plates for exam week and left it at that.



SUGARFOOT

One bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with something to eat.

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

02

## Three things go in.

The first is how evenly the hours are shared. The second is whether every regular job has a clear owner, from the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). The third is how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on. A

**workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start, since rough notes on the back of an envelope do fine.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

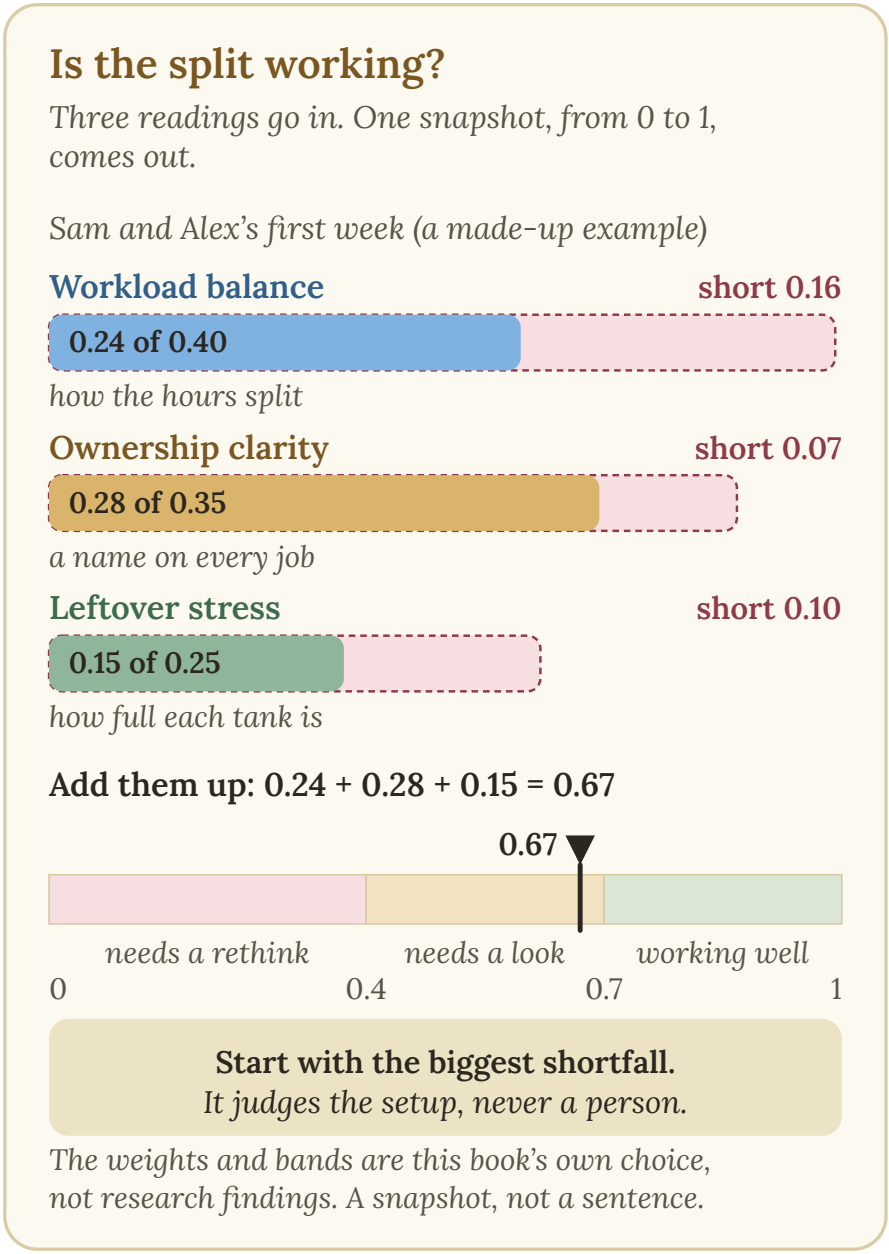



FIGURE 7 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

## Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1 and one person doing everything scores 0, whichever person it is. If you've agreed an uneven split that suits you, perhaps because one of you works longer hours outside the home, compare against that split instead. With three or more of you, compare each person's share with an even share (100 divided by the number of people) or with the split you agreed. Three partners who log 30 hours of home jobs between them, at 15, 9 and 6, would each have 10 as an even share. The "Who does what?" page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic for you.

Log one week each, and put in the small jobs that take under ten minutes. Those are the ones that go missing. They are often the ones that start the rows, too.

**Everyone's share comes to more than 100%**

In a classic set of experiments, spouses asked for their own share of joint jobs gave answers that, added together, usually came to more than 100%. Nobody was lying. We simply remember our own contributions better, which is the best argument I know for writing the week down instead of guessing.

**Ross and Sicoly (1979)** · *Strong: a classic, widely replicated finding*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

**Who does what? Quick look**

*Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)*

### Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

| Your name | Their name |
|---|---|
| *Wren* | *Josh* |
| Person 3 | |
| *Mei* | |

| Job | Who mostly does it |
|---|---|
| *Dishes* | *Shared* |
| *Laundry* | *Shared* |
| *Cleaning the bathroom* | *Josh* |
| *Cooking dinner* | *Mei* |
| *Grocery shopping* | *Wren* |
| *Paying bills* | *Wren* |
| *Noticing what's running low* | *Wren* |
| *Planning the week* | *Mei* |
| *Remembering dates and appointments* | *Wren* |

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

*Made-up example. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.*

Fill in your own: Who does what? Quick look (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

## Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names. The owner does the job from start to finish. The backstop notices if it slipped and checks in gently, which is very different from supervising. It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner and divide by all the

jobs on the list, and leave the unowned jobs on the list, because they matter most. A *decision* you make together, such as which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)" and counts as owned. A *job* that needs doing gets one name.

Most of what goes wrong in shared work isn't incompetence. It's unclear ownership: work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it quietly lands on whoever notices first.

Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his repeat prescription. For a fortnight each of them thought the other had ordered it, and each, it turned out, had thought about ringing to check and hadn't, so as not to seem like she was nagging. He ran out on a Sunday. The out-of-hours pharmacy was forty minutes away.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

A job without a name tends to land on whoever notices first. Write one owner next to each job, and the guessing stops.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

## Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), where a higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your two scores, but if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the overall result looks fine. A setup that only works when you're both well rested can't last, so more stress lowers the result.

Doreen is raising her two grandchildren and scores 0.70. Her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. The average looks fine, but Doreen's 0.70 is the headline, whatever the average says, and her son, looking at the two numbers side by side, went quiet for a long time. Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before you look at the other's.

**How loaded it feels**

The Perceived Stress Scale, one of the most used stress questionnaires, asks how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded life has felt lately, and its scores track symptoms of depression and illness. That's close to what the stress tank asks: not how much happened, but how loaded it feels.

**Cohen, Kamarck and Mermelstein (1983)** · *Strong: one of the most widely used stress questionnaires*

06

## One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

A result of 0.70 or above reads as *working well*, meaning the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as *needs a look*, because something is drifting, often who owns what, and below 0.40 it reads as *needs a rethink, together*. The result is called the setup score. It is a simple weighted sum, in which the hours count most, then the owners, then stress, and although it looks like a probability it isn't one.

Two friends who run a café together scored 0.55. So nothing was broken, just something drifting, and it took them about four minutes to find it, which was the Monday ordering. Each of them had assumed for months that the other did it, and it had been getting done, more or less, by whoever panicked first on Tuesday morning. Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

**Is the setup working for everyone?**

*Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years*

## Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
*Rosemary*

Person 2 (optional)
*Ken*

### 1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the "Who does what?" page: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

### 2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

### 3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

**Working well**
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

*It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.*

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

## Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add, and in the middle band it's often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. A separated couple scored 0.62 and found their biggest gap was that nobody owned the school forms. That was the only thing they changed that month, and both of them were quietly relieved it wasn't something bigger.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

08

## It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you

feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

"So I'm the problem," said Lee, looking at 0.35.

**When a measure becomes a target**

Goodhart's law, from an economist writing about monetary policy, says a number tends to stop telling you anything once people are pushed to hit it. That's the reason this score is for looking at together and never for winning.

**Goodhart (1975)** · *Moderate: an economist's observation, later generalised and widely seen in practice*

"No," said his partner. "The bathroom hasn't got an owner and you work nights."

They started there. Before you begin, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back towards your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SUNDAY EVENING

*Two week-long logs. Two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows and the other has 18, and for a moment neither of you says anything and the fridge hums.*

*"I honestly didn't know about half of these," one of you says.*

*"Which half?"*

## Words this chapter uses

A **log** is a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took. The **owner** does a job from start to finish, including remembering it, and the **backstop** notices if a job slipped and checks in gently. Your **stress tank** is how much stress you're already carrying from the rest of life. The **setup** is the way you share the work right now, which can always be changed, and the **setup score** is the one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing that the soap is running low all belong in your log.

## On your own: is your own load working?

You can ask the same question of your own week. Are you spending more energy than comes back? Add up what you carry, jobs and worries both, and set it beside what refills you. If it runs in the red, change your side, by dropping, delaying, asking or saying no kindly. A limit describes your supply. It says nothing about your worth. After her breakup, Leanne had the children every other week and filled the quiet weeks with favours for friends, including one memorable flat-pack wardrobe that took nine hours and a hospital visit (her thumb). Writing it down showed her she never rested (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

## One setup, looked at twice

Three people share a flat above a bakery, and everyone agrees that cleaning matters while nobody owns the bathroom. Their first check scores 0.67, and the biggest shortfall is ownership: eight of the twelve jobs have a name, and the bathroom, the bins, the recycling and the hallway don't. They give each of those four jobs an owner and a backstop. A month later, with the hours and their stress tanks about the same as before, the score is 0.79. Ownership went from 0.67 to 1.00, and that part counts for 0.35 of the score, so it adds

0.12. The bathroom is better. The recycling is still a sore point, because the one who owns it works late on collection night, and that's the job they're arguing about next. Shift work, illness and caring can all make hours look even while sleep or energy is not, and an uneven split agreed on purpose can be the fair one (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and When one of you is ill, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

**Our room agreement**

*Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates*

## Our room agreement

Your name
*Kayla*

Their name
*Bea*

Quiet hours
*11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.*

Guests (daytime)
*Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.*

Overnight guests
*Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.*

Cleaning
*Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.*

Borrowing
*Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.*

Lights and alarms
*Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.*

How we bring up problems
*Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.*

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

*They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.*

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

## Common mix-ups

A low number doesn't mean the relationship is failing. It means the current setup needs changing, and setups change all the time. Please don't guess the numbers. A guessed number is a feeling with a decimal point, so use your written logs. One of you can't fill it in for both, either. Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank. And fair doesn't have to mean exactly 50/50. Fair is what you both agree to with your eyes open, and an uneven split you chose together can be the fair one. Two kinds of fair (page 79) looks at this.

## Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs, from the nursery bag and the jabs to the party invitations, the next size of clothes and the nights. That's why the mental load (see the work nobody sees, page 27) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it. Log the children's jobs too, with the thinking time, and count the nights. Hand over whole jobs, like clothes and sizes or the GP and the jabs, so the new owner does the noticing too, in their own way. If a baby is on the way, write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights, and agree to look again at six weeks, at three months and before either of you goes back to work. In the first weeks, share by energy more than by hours, so whoever was up in the night gets the rest.

Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, who is three, and Poppy, who is eight months, and Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes came out nearly

even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They left the minutes alone and moved one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth. In the first fortnight Alfie went to nursery in a vest in October. Hollie said nothing, heroically.

YOU COULD SAY

"Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

**Who did what, with small children**

*Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts*

## Who did what

Person A
*Hollie*

Person B
*Gareth*

Week beginning
*12 October 2026*

### Part A: Who did what, this week

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Mon* | *Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk* | *Hollie* | *10* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Tue* | *Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP* | *Hollie* | *15* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Tue* | *Bath and bedtime, both children* | *Gareth* | *45* | *Asked for* |
| *Wed* | *Reply to a party invite and buy the present* | *Hollie* | *25* | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Wed* | *Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size* | *Hollie* | *40* | *Noticed and handled* |

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Thu* | *Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights* | *Hollie* | 20 | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Thu* | *Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend* | *Gareth* | 75 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Fri* | *Remember the nursery photo money and form* | *Hollie* | 10 | *Thinking and planning* |
| *Fri* | *Night wakings with Poppy* | *Hollie* | 60 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sat* | *Swimming lesson with Alfie* | *Gareth* | 60 | *Asked for* |
| *Sat* | *Big food shop and nappies* | *Both* | 80 | *Asked for* |
| *Sun* | *Washing for both children, to put away* | *Hollie* | 50 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sun* | *Fix the stair gate* | *Gareth* | 20 | *Noticed and handled* |
| *Sun* | *Update the family calendar and the childcare rota* | *Hollie* | 20 | *Thinking and planning* |

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

**Hollie**
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

**Gareth**
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

**Workload balance score**
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

**Unasked-for work**
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

**Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no**

Left blank this week.

*Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.*

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

## If only one of you wants to try this

That's common, and you can still start. Log your own week, score your own tank, and then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers. A dad noticed he was spending five hours a week driving his sixteen-year-old to training and back. He said so, without any accusation in it, and they agreed on a bus pass for two days a week. His son grumbled for a fortnight and then started quite enjoying the bus, where nobody asked him how training went. Share one finding at a time, then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at home?

## More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

To run the check, each of you first logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), because the number only means something if you each wrote your own. Next, fill in the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet, and each score your own stress tank on the same day. Put the three numbers into the calculator (spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working), look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together and check again in a month.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*The unseen work the check counts*
page 18

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*The stress input, explained*
page 64

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*Fixing the setup with small, kind changes*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well**
*When one person carries the care*
read online

PUT IT TO USE



**Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



**One owner per job**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

# III

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

# Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

*Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: reading your own tank
11. Common mix-ups
12. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
13. If only one of you wants to try this
14. More for your situation


IN SHORT

- **A full tank overflows**, so stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute**, and say the band out loud so nobody has to guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles**, and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means later**, so pause, name a time and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

*"Did you remember to ring the dentist?"*

*A perfectly pleasant question. What comes out of you in reply is about four sizes too big for it, with a bit about the car thrown in for good measure, and you can hear it happening while it happens, like watching yourself trip on a stair.*

01

## A full tank overflows.

If you're already tired or stretched from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction, which is simply human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you've both calmed down.

It's eight in the morning and Marnie has just done a twelve-hour night shift and is standing in the kitchen in her coat. Her housemate, eating cornflakes, asks if she saw his message about the electricity meter. She bites his head off, properly, though really it was twelve hours on her feet that did the biting. The meter just happened to be standing at the end of them. She apologised at four in the afternoon, when she woke up, via a note under his door. The note said, "Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I'm running on empty."

**Stress from outside leaks in**

Daily diaries from newlywed couples showed that spouses under more stress outside the relationship reacted more strongly to everyday irritations inside it. Marnie's morning is a fair example.

**Neff and Karney (2009)** · *Moderate: daily-diary studies of newlyweds; correlational*

02

## Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of you and how much you carried in with you. Being upset about the dishes and being exhausted, with the dishes as the thing you happened to notice, are different problems. Some of what we bring in is much older, like an understanding from growing up that whoever notices the mess has to clean it. If a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens

came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) helps you find where it started.

Corey is fourteen and has had a horrible day at school, the sort he won't talk about. He comes home and finds his brother has taken the phone charger, again. The explosion that follows can be heard two doors down. The charger was the last drop in a tank that had been full since lunchtime.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Before a hard talk, check how full your own tank is. Five quick questions, about two minutes, and you'll know whether now is the time.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

03

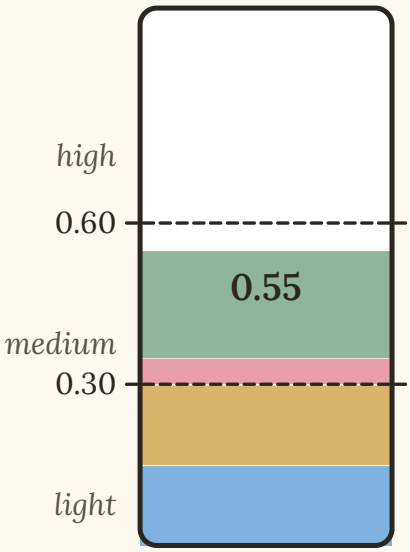
## Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is, and a higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4, which are sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels and time pressure today, then add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium and 0.60 or more is high. If it's been high for a long time it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it.

Vince has been looking after his wife since her hip operation. He scored 0.65 three days running. That told him something he hadn't let himself think, which was that he needed help more than he needed to try harder. He sat with it for an evening, in the chair by the window with the radio on low. Then he rang his son, who said, "Dad, I've been waiting for you to ask since March."

## How full is your stress tank?

*Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.*




**Sam today**

| | |
|---|---|
| Time pressure today | 4 |
| Body: hungry, unwell, in pain | 0 |
| Unresolved conflict | 1 |
| Workload elsewhere | 3 |
| Sleep debt | 3 |
| **11 ÷ 20** | **= 0.55** |

**Medium: say it before a hard talk.**
*"Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today."*

*Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.*

FIGURE 8 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. The scores shown are an example; the items and bands are this book's.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

**How much are you carrying?**

*Rosa, who shares her mum's care with her brother*

## How much are you carrying?

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name
*Rosa*

Date
*7 October 2026*

### The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR STRESS TANK

**Your stress tank today**
High (13 out of 20 points)

**What to do**
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

**If it can't wait**
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

**Filled most by**
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

**Stress tank score**
0.65 out of 1.00

### Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
*Mum's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.*

*Made-up example. Higher means a fuller stress tank. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.*

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02)

04

## Three everyday states.

Knowing whether you're calm and connected, revved up or running on empty tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. The labels come from polyvagal theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists, and here they're used

only as everyday words. In one long-distance couple, he takes the video call at midnight his time and is usually running on empty by then, so they've moved the hard talks to Saturday mornings. It helps to know one body clue for each state. A tight jaw is a common one for revved up.

05

## There are seven angles on the same moment.

The seven angles are tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure the other sees what they see. The "See their side" step of Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) is built on these seven angles and helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask in place of guesses.

Christmas, again, and Sasha sees it from family habit, because they always go to her mum's. There's a stocking with each child's name on it, stitched in 2016, and her mum would be heartbroken. Kemi sees it from fairness: they went to her mum's last year, and the year before, and, now that he counts, the year before that.

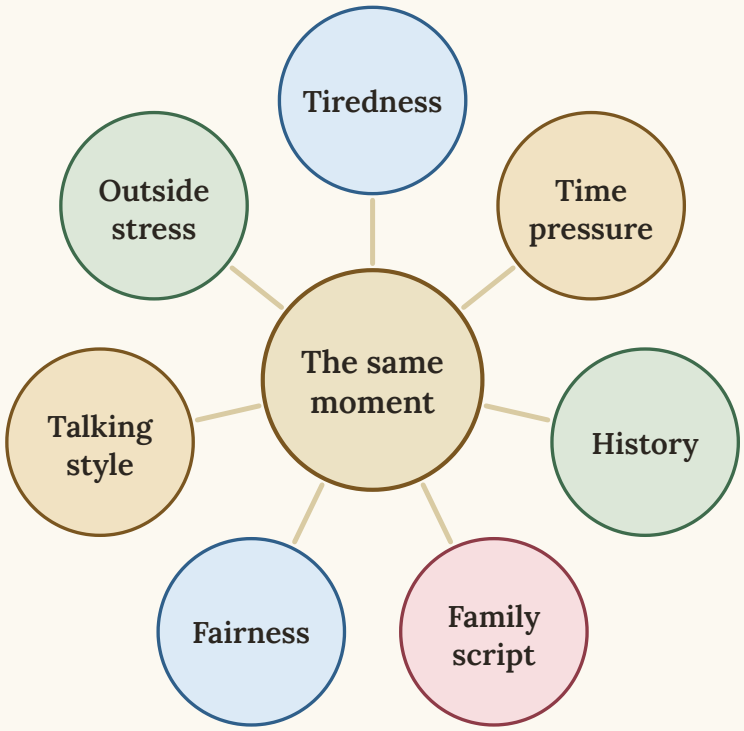
**Naive realism**

Lee Ross and Andrew Ward described the quiet assumption that we see things as they really are, so anyone who disagrees must be uninformed or unreasonable. Saying your angle out loud is a small way of admitting you have one.

**Ross and Ward (1996)** · *Strong: a foundational account whose predictions are well replicated*

## Seven angles on the same moment

*Which one are you looking from right now?*




**An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.**
*Name your own. Ask about theirs.*

*Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Rewind the talk's "See their side" uses them.*

FIGURE 9 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

**Rewind the talk: see their side**

*Hana, about her friend Lou*

## See their side

1. What happened?

*I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe".*

2. Who are they to you?

Partner · Family · Roommate · *Friend* · Coworker · Co-parent · My teen or child · Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected · Revved up · *Running on empty* · I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day · *Little sleep* · Rushed or late · Money worries · *Caring for someone* · Not feeling their best · A noisy or crowded place · Other people were there · *It was a text or message* · It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot · They take words literally · *They need time to process* · They think out loud · They're very direct · They hint rather than say · They like a plan · Noise, light or crowds get to them · Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before · They grew up with it done differently · *It's a sore topic for them* · They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload · *a message, call or news you didn't see* · something they had already planned or done · how it looked from where they stood · a promise someone else made them · how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done | *the reason behind your timing*

what you actually meant | how tired or stretched you were | the part already done

a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

*each other's tone, in writing* | what was going on in the other's head

what would happen next | what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether, for you, you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

*These are possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.*

Fill in your own: Rewind the talk: see their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder)

06

## Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing, so the useful question is which angle each of you is seeing it from. Two brothers argued for a year about their late mum's house. One saw thirty years of memories. Height marks on the kitchen door frame, the apple tree, the step where she sat to take her shoes off.

The other saw a roof that needed £9,000 of work. Both of them were looking at the real house. In the end they sold it, and the one who saw the memories took the door frame with the height marks on it, which is now leaning against a wall in his garage.

WORDS TO TRY

"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

07

## Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your tank is and which angle you're seeing from, ideally right at the start.

Two colleagues had a meeting about a missed deadline that both were dreading. One of them, feeling foolish, began with, "Before we start, I'm about half full today and I'm mostly seeing this from the time angle." After a pause the other said, "Right. I'm pretty full. Fairness angle, if I'm honest." It felt very odd, like reading out your own weather forecast. The meeting was shorter and calmer than the last one, and nobody cried in the toilets afterwards, which last time somebody had.



TIDBIT

Say your number out loud. "I'm about a seven today." Two seconds, and nobody has to guess.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

08

## A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause and never a way out of the talk. Say when you'll come back, and let the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round if you still feel hot, and if you are still at 0.60 or more after two rounds, pick a new time and say when.

It's about phone time, and a dad and his fourteen-year-old are both shouting. "I'm too wound up," he says, "I'll talk to you at seven." She slams

her door, and at seven he knocks. It matters more than anything he says once he's inside. That isn't much, or very good, and it is a lot better than not knocking.

**Flooding**
John Gottman's long-term studies of couples gave a name to the point where someone is so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard. A full tank means later partly because a flooded person can't really do now.

**Gottman (1994)** · *Moderate: large observational studies; some specific predictions are debated*

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

MONDAY MORNING

*The post, eleven envelopes and a pizza menu, on the kitchen table, where they have been since Thursday. One of you sees a to-do list. The other sees proof that nobody in this house ever opens the post except them. You try saying your angles out loud, like the book says, and it helps for about a minute. Then the gas bill comes up.*

*The pile is still there at lunchtime.*

## Words this chapter uses

Your **stress tank** is how much stress you're already carrying before this moment even starts. **Leftover stress** is the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day, while **this-moment stress** is caused by what is in front of you right now. An **angle** is the point of view you're seeing a moment from, such as tiredness or fairness.

## On your own: reading your own tank

On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your tank before you react. Check it for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern. Ask yourself before a hard moment how much of it is left over from earlier. Decide on a calm day what settles you, so it's ready when you need it. Living alone after a breakup, Beth noticed she snapped at her sister on the phone every single Monday. Her morning readings showed why. Sunday night was her worst sleep of the week, every week, without fail. Now she asks for Tuesday instead, and her sister has stopped asking what's wrong (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

## Common mix-ups

A big reaction sometimes means it was a big deal. Quite often it means the tank was already full. A high score is never an excuse, either. It's a note to come back later, never a pass to skip the talk. You can't tell how full someone else's tank is, however well you know them, which is why each person scores only themselves. And a pause isn't the silent treatment, because a pause has a time to come back, which is why you always say when.

## Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank. Being quiet, clingy or cross for a few hours after a handover is common and usually says nothing bad about the other home. Give them landing time, with a snack and something familiar and no questions about the other home for the first hour. The child is never the messenger. Adult news goes adult to adult. For money, follow any formal arrangement. Split the extras by a ratio you agree, and settle up once a month from one list. With an ex, share the band and keep the story, as in "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?", and your private life stays yours. If an ex won't cooperate but isn't dangerous, parallel parenting can work, with written messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school and your own list for your own home. When there are new partners, the parent stays the owner of

anything involving the other home, and a step-parent starts as a friendly adult rather than the one who tells the children off.

Harriet gives Freya, who is eight, and Arlo, who is five, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's, and she has stopped asking "How was it?" at the front door. Sunday evenings are calmer. Arlo still cries at bedtime on changeover days, and she's waiting to see whether that eases. Some weeks she thinks it is. Some weeks she isn't sure.

WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE)

"Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on 6 November and costs £24. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If you are afraid of your ex, a shared plan isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

## If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this from your own side. Check your own tank, name your own angle, pause and come back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help, and when one person starts saying it out loud, the other quite often follows. Lauren visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash about his health. She started opening each visit with, "I'm a bit tired today, so if I go quiet it isn't you." He never scored anything himself. He thinks the whole idea is daft. Still, the visits got calmer, and one Sunday in November he said, unprompted, while filling the kettle, "I'm a bit tired today and all, love."

**A note on safety:** A full tank explains a reaction. It never excuses shouting, threats or hurting anyone. If someone's "stress" often turns into fear for you, that isn't a tank problem. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If sharing how you feel ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

## More for your situation

Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

Before your next hard conversation, score the five things in How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), add them up and divide by 20, then say one sentence out loud about your tank and your angle. If either of you scores 0.60 or more, put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour, and agree on a time to come back.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system** — read online
*The ladder, flooding and rest*

**Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other** — read online
*The angles and stories behind a reaction*

**Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger** — read online
*What to do in the hot minutes*

**Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words** — read online
*Checking your own weather first*


PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**How much are you carrying?**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

# IV

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

# Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

*Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. On your own: your own kind of fair
10. Common mix-ups
11. Money between you
12. A couple and a housemate
13. More for your situation
14. A note on safety


IN SHORT

- **There are two kinds of fair**, by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?), so agree which one you are using.
- **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner**, and when you cover for someone, say so out loud.
- **Let a comment land before you react** by noticing it, naming it and then deciding what to say.
- **Keep the two questions apart**, because whether the job was done is a fact and whether the comment hurt is a feeling.

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

*One of you counts hours. The other counts who noticed the job needed doing in the first place. You are both counting honestly, in two different currencies, then arguing about the exchange rate. This usually happens on a Sunday evening and usually, for reasons nobody can explain, about the oven.*

01

## There are two kinds of fair.

One kind asks whether everything got done. The other asks whether each person did what they said they would. Both are reasonable, and friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realising.

Nisha and Kezia share a room in halls. Nisha thinks a week was fair if the room is tidy by Friday, whoever tidied it. Kezia thinks it was fair if each of them kept her own half clean. For most of the first term each thought the other was being unreasonable and said so to other people. Neither of them was. It came out at two in the morning over a shared packet of noodles, and they both laughed until the girl next door banged on the wall.

**More than one kind of fair**

Morton Deutsch argued that equity (you get out what you put in) is only one fairness rule, alongside equality (the same for everyone) and need, and that people lean on different ones in different settings. Research broadly agrees that the setting decides.

**Deutsch (1975)** · *Moderate: an influential theory, broadly supported*

YOU COULD SAY

"When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

## Two kinds of fair

*Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when you use different ones without saying so.*

### Fair by results

*Asks: Did it all get done?*

Guards: Will the home keep running?

Good: flexible. Watch: it can hide who always steps in.

- Bins ✓
- Dentist ✓
- Forms ✓

### Fair by promises

*Asks: Did each of us do what we agreed?*

Guards: Can I rely on you?

Good: clear. Watch: it can feel rigid in a hard week.

- Bins · Sam ✓
- Dentist · Maya ✗
- Forms · Lin ✓

### The agreement: look to the owner

**Bins · owner: Sam**

*second name: Alex, who notices and asks once*

*Once a job has a named owner, judge it by whether the owner did their part (swapping or asking ahead counts), not by whether someone quietly covered. Made-up examples.*

FIGURE 10 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable; trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

02

## Fair by results.

This kind of fair judges by outcomes, by whether the right things got done by whoever had the time or energy. It's flexible and easy-going, which is lovely when it works. Done carefully it counts the cost to whoever covered. Done carelessly it hides who is always stepping in.

Marjorie is raising her grandchildren. Her grown-up son helps with whatever's needed when he's home, cheerfully and well. The house runs, and she is always, always the one who notices what's needed. She didn't see it herself until she marked, for one week, every job she picked up that wasn't planned. It came to forty-one, and she showed her son. He said, "Forty-*one*?" and then, after a bit, "Right."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

**Who does what? The Money tab**

*Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes*

### Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
£ *(pounds)*

| Bill | Grace paid (£) | Ruth paid (£) | How it's shared |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Rent* | 1,100 | 700 | *Shared, split* |
| *Power and water* | 160 | 0 | *Shared, split* |
| *Internet and phones* | 0 | 90 | *Shared, split* |
| *Groceries* | 300 | 250 | *Shared, split* |

| | Grace brings in (£) | Ruth brings in (£) | How it's shared |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Pay* | 4,200 | 2,800 | *Money coming in* |

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace £1,560; Ruth £1,040.

Coming in: £7,000 (Grace £4,200, Ruth £2,800). After shared bills: £4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in £260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

*Made-up example. Money is a fair topic only where nobody controls the other's money.*

Fill in your own: Who does what? (Money tab) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

03

## Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It's clear and steady, and it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way. Two business partners run a café. One owns the ordering, the other owns the staff rota. When the rota is late (it's the Thursday before a bank holiday, it is always late then) they ask the rota owner about it, not "the team". And nobody takes it personally, or not for long.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take the bins?"

04

## Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop, who notices if it slipped and checks in gently without supervising, and it can be the same person. If the job is yours, the question is whether you did it, and somebody quietly covering

for you doesn't answer that. It also protects the person who keeps filling the gaps.

In one stepfamily, Ethan, who is thirteen, owns feeding the dog. His stepmum Claire is the second name. When the bowl is empty at seven and the dog is staring at it with enormous meaning, Claire says "Dog's dinner?" once, just that. She doesn't do it for him and she doesn't lecture. For the first month this nearly killed her. Ethan now feeds the dog most nights before anyone mentions it, and the dog has stopped staring at Claire.

**Opening the gate**

In 97 couples with babies, fathers did more of the day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them, and when mothers were very critical, fathers' own beliefs about being involved made less difference. It's one US sample, but Claire's single "Dog's dinner?" is gate-opening in miniature.

**Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues (2008)** · *Moderate: an observational study of one US sample; correlational*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

**One owner per job**

*Dee and Mark, foster carers*

### One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A
*Dee*

Person B
*Mark*

Date of this list
*4 October 2026*

The split you agreed (optional)
*Dee works three days; Mark works full time*

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Social worker visits* | *Monthly* | 1.5 | *Dee* | *Mark* | *Mark joins by video when he can* |

| Job | How often | Roughly how long? | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Reviews and meetings* | *As needed* | 2 | *Dee* | *Mark* | *Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones* |
| *Daily log and placement paperwork* | *Daily* | 0.5 | *Dee* | *Mark* | *Mark writes it on Dee's work days* |
| *Contact visits and calls with their family* | *Weekly* | 1.5 | *Mark* | *Dee* | *Saturday mornings* |
| *School liaison (designated teacher, plans)* | *As needed* | 1 | *Dee* | | |
| *Being there after contact* | *As needed* | 1 | *Mark* | *Dee* | *Quiet tea, no questions* |
| *Health and therapy appointments* | *As needed* | 1.5 | *Dee* | | |
| *Training and support group* | *Monthly* | 2 | *Mark* | | *Mark's turn this term* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

**How the jobs are spread**
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time". Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
*Dee and Mark*

*"Being there after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

## Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely, and it helps to mention it, so the help is seen. "I put the bins out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

Two sisters take turns driving their dad to his appointments. When one covers for the other, she texts the same day. *Took Dad Thurs, you were on lates. All fine, bloods normal, he flirted with the receptionist.* It takes ten seconds to send and stops the help going invisible. The second half of the message is, they both agree, the important bit.



SUGARFOOT

Covering for someone is kind. Say that you did, gently, or it turns into the quiet sort of resentment that nobody mentions until Christmas.

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

06

## Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say "Give me a second." The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically in a fraction of a second, while this pause is a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether the remark needs an answer now or later, or at all.

Two in the afternoon. Fran has come downstairs after a night shift, hair everywhere. Her husband looks up from the table. "Oh, you're up." She has been asleep for six hours, dreaming about a ward round, and what she hears is *at last*. She's halfway into a reply before she stops and says, "Give me a second, I'm really tired." He looks puzzled, because he'd meant he was glad to see her. He'd saved her the last of the soup (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). Agree your own "give me a second" phrase today, while things are calm.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a comment stings, give it a minute to land before you answer. This workpaper is a short check for your reply.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

07

## Notice, name, decide.

First notice that a comment landed hard. Then name it, kindly ("That hit harder than you probably meant"). Once you've settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words.

"You *never* listen," his fifteen-year-old said, on the stairs. Andy felt his chest go tight, and a speech started assembling itself somewhere behind his teeth. He wanted very much to list the times he had listened. What he said was, "Ouch. That stings. And I do want to hear you properly." Then he decided it needed a real talk, the next evening, after her swimming, in the car, which is where they talk best, both looking at the road.

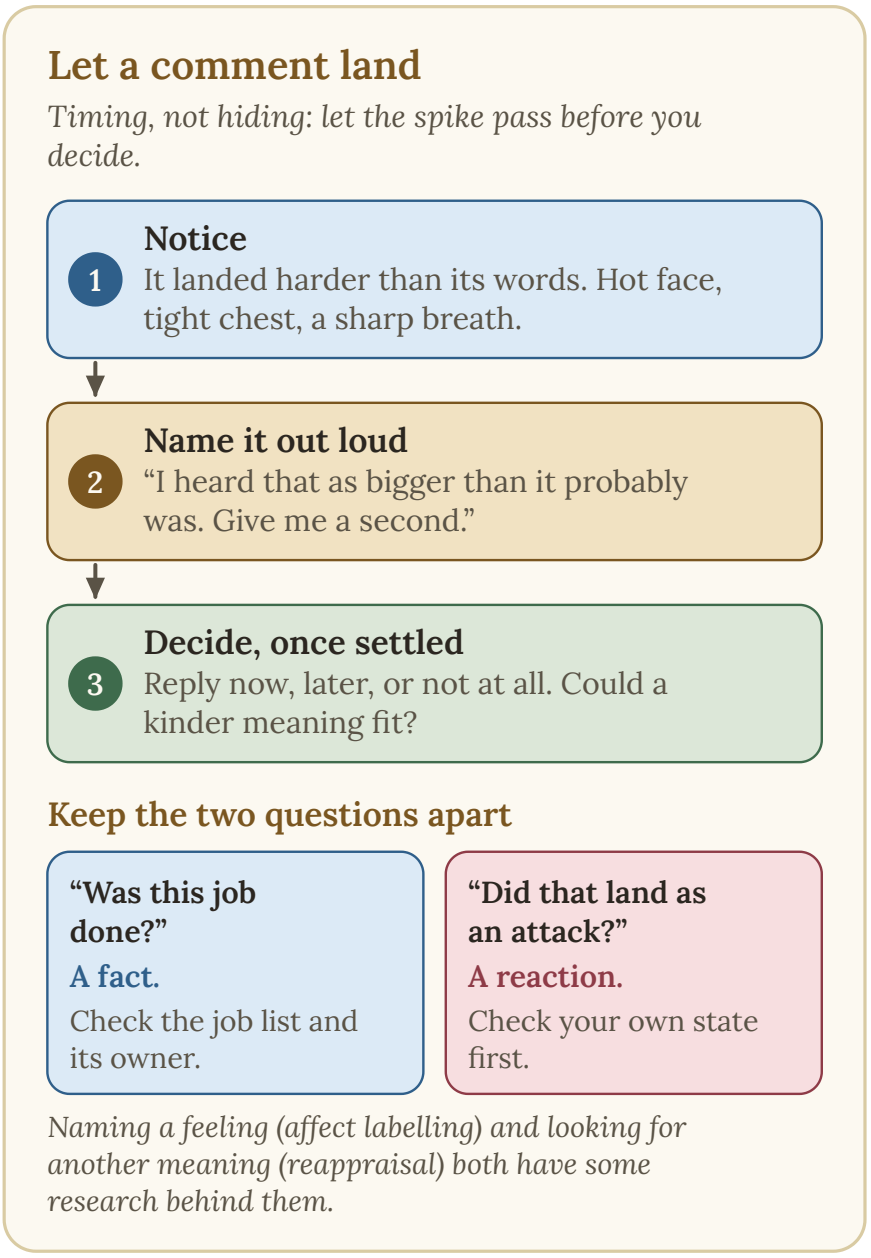



FIGURE 11 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

**Say it so it lands**

*Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi*

## Say it so it lands

Your name
*Carla*

Date
*8 October 2026*

### Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction
*Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.*

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)
*The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4.*

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)
*I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.*

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)
*Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?*

### Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(*Yes*) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (*Not sure*)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(*Yes*) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

(*Their words*) A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

**Ways to say it**
Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

**Suggestions**
Your own stress tank is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

*The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.*

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09)

08

## Keep the two questions apart.

Whether the job was done is a question about a fact. Whether the comment hurt is a question about a feeling. Both matter, and each goes better in its own conversation.

Separated parents share their children across two homes. The bag came back on Sunday without the school shoes, and with it a text about the shoes that felt, to the one who received it, very cold. They sorted the shoes first, on the phone, in about two minutes. They talked about the text the following Sunday. It took longer and was more awkward, and it was better for waiting a week (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting). When a talk tangles, "Fact or feeling?" is a good question to ask out loud. Finish one before you start the other.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

*Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the bins but works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken them out three weeks running. At the catch-up Sam mentions it, not very smoothly. Alex goes a bit red and admits that Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month, with Sam taking the bins and Alex taking the recycling and the weekly grocery order, and to settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter V* (*page 96*).

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

*"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, slightly flat. It was meant as a thank-you, and it came out sounding like a criticism. Before you know it you've answered the criticism, the person who said thank you is defending a thank-you, and the dishes are still in the rack.*

## On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what it means to you, and which jobs are truly yours. Write down what fair means to you in one sentence, and list the jobs you own alongside the ones you picked up without ever agreeing to. Errol lives alone and has his children every other weekend. His sentence, after a lot of crossing out, is that fair means not doing their jobs for them just because he misses them (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). He finds this very hard on Sunday afternoons, when he'd

happily do everything if it meant another hour. Pick one job you took on without agreeing, and either keep it on purpose or raise it on a calm day.

## Common mix-ups

If it got done, there may still be a problem, because someone may be paying for it in time and energy. Holding the owner to the job isn't being strict. It's keeping the agreement you both made, which is kinder than quiet resentment. Letting a comment land doesn't mean ignoring it. It's about timing, and you still get to answer. And please don't save up months of covering to bring out all at once. A long list lands like a bill, so mention covering as it happens.

## Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Some couples put everything into one pot. Some keep their money separate and pay agreed bills, often half each, which is fair by promises, the same rule for both. Others each pay into a shared pot in line with what they earn and keep the rest, which is fair by results, since each is left with a similar share. Many couples mix them, with a joint account for bills and food and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories, how money worked at home when you were growing up, then move on to the numbers and to a "talk first" amount for big purchases that applies to both of you. A limit you both chose and both keep is care, not control.

Niamh takes home £2,600 a month and Tariq £1,900, and their rent and bills will be £1,500. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay, so she pays £870 and he pays £630.

**Having a say**

Procedural justice research, which began with Thibaut and Walker, finds that whether people feel a decision was reached fairly, and above all whether they had a voice in it, shapes how they feel about the result. A good reason to work a split out together rather than hand one over.

**Thibaut and Walker (1975)** · *Strong: one of the more robust findings in social psychology, though early lab methods were criticised*

WORDS TO TRY

"Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?"
"Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

## A couple and a housemate

A couple sharing a home with a housemate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. It helps to keep two lists, **house jobs** for all three of you, such as the bins, the bathroom, the bills and the landlord, and **couple jobs** for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, not in bed the night before. Hear the housemate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms, and never ask them to referee. Ollie and Hamza share a flat with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room, since the couple has the bigger one, and the bills by person, and all three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month, with biscuits, which Bex insists is the only reason she turns up. Anything that comes up in between gets the stock answer, "That's a house question, let's decide it when Bex is here."

## More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · More than two partners (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own

On a calm, easy day, each of you can say which kind of fair comes more naturally, results or promises. Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job), with a second name for someone who notices if it slips. Finally, agree a short phrase for when something lands hard ("Give me a second" does fine), along with the promise that whoever asked for a second will come back to it.

## A note on safety

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about what's fair ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. Rules one person sets for the other, with checking, punishment or money held back, are control, and that is not your fault. See normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together#control).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH SOMEONE YOU TRUST
>
> "Things at home don't feel fair, and I'm scared to bring it up. Can I talk it through with you?"

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Repair and apologies that land*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works**
*Letting words land before you reply*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life**
*Fairness as a value you choose together*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture**
*How a group's norms decide what feels fair*
read online

PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**Say it so it lands**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands

# V

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

# The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

*Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. A look-back, three months in
11. Common mix-ups
12. Starting out: before you move in
13. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
14. More for your situation
15. On your own: a monthly look at yourself


THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

*The bins again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth you had last Tuesday, word for word. You know your lines and so do they.*

*Or you could notice that this is the third Tuesday running, and wonder what it is about Tuesdays.*

01

## Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

Four flatmates had an overflowing bathroom bin every week, and every week it seemed like bad luck, until they looked at the month together and saw it had happened every single week since September. One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and patterns are easiest to see when you look at a whole month at once.

In my old job the step that got skipped more than any other was going back afterwards to check that the fix had actually held, and skipping it is exactly how the same problem turns up again three years later. This chapter is that step, made small. A careful, friendly glance over the month, closer to a self-check than an inspection. Choose a monthly date now, the last Sunday, say, and put it in everyone's calendar.

**Latent conditions**
James Reason, writing about accidents in organisations, showed how they grow out of latent conditions, gaps that sit quietly in a system until they meet an ordinary slip on an ordinary day. A job with no owner is a latent condition.

**Reason (1997)** · *Strong: foundational in safety science*

02

## You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), where a few lines a week is enough, and your job list from One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). Twenty minutes is usually plenty. If either of your stress tanks is high that day, at 0.60 or more on How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), move it a day or two.

Kat and Nathan work different shifts and keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones, mostly typed at red lights. They do the look-back on the one evening a month they're both off, with a takeaway from the Nepalese place. It has become, slightly to their embarrassment, the evening of the month they look forward to most.

03

## Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job slipped if it was noticed and not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗, because three or four in a month is a real pattern.

Two foster carers found the reading log had been missed three weeks out of four. Both of them had an explanation ready. They marked the ✗ in

pencil first, together, before either of them said anything at all, which is much harder than it sounds and much the best order. Then the explanations, which turned out to be the same one.

04

### A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

That kind of problem gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish, so the fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it.

In a house with three partners, "whoever's free" did the online grocery order. It was late three times this month, once by a whole day. With nobody owning it, everybody assumed someone else had it in hand. One Friday there was no milk at all in the house, and four jars of mustard.

**Diffusion of responsibility**

In a famous experiment, people who thought others could also hear someone having a seizure were slower to help, and less likely to, because each felt less responsible. A grocery order is a long way from an emergency, but "whoever's free" runs on the same arithmetic.

**Darley and Latané (1968)** · *Strong: classic and widely replicated, though weaker in clearly dangerous emergencies*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

**One owner per job: a list for two homes**

*Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes*

## One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
*Laura*

Person B
*Dan*

Date of this list
*1 October 2026*

The split you agreed (optional)
*Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5*

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Pack the handoff bag* | *Weekly* | *Laura* | *Dan* | *Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it* |
| *Send medicine and chargers with the bag* | *Weekly* | *Laura* | *Dan* | *Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card* |
| *School forms and permission slips* | *As needed* | *Dan* | *Laura* | |
| *Reply to school emails and apps* | *Weekly* | *Dan* | | *Dan reads them Sunday night* |
| *Kids' doctor and dentist visits* | *As needed* | *Dan* | | *Dan books; tells Laura the date* |
| *Homework help (Laura's weeks)* | *Daily* | *Laura* | | |
| *Homework help (Dan's weeks)* | *Daily* | *Dan* | | |
| *Activities and sign-ups* | *As needed* | *Dan* | *Laura* | *Swimming and Cubs* |

| Job | How often | Owner | Helper or backup | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Buy clothes as they outgrow them* | *As needed* | *Laura* | | *Receipts in the shared folder* |
| *Big decisions (school, health, new activities)* | *As needed* | *Both (decide together)* | | *A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff* |

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

**Jobs with an owner**
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

**How the jobs sit across the homes**
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5". Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

*Made-up example. If one parent is afraid of the other, a shared list isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? on this site.*

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

## Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

If a job has no clear owner, update the job list. If its owner can't keep up, have a kind, honest talk. If there was a short-term cause, like a bout of flu, note it and move on.

The homework folder kept coming back unsigned. Two separated parents looked at it at the look-back and went through the three kinds, out loud, quite carefully, because last time they'd argued. Was nobody sure which home signs it, was one of them swamped, or was it just the week she had

flu? It was the first one. It had been the first one since September (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

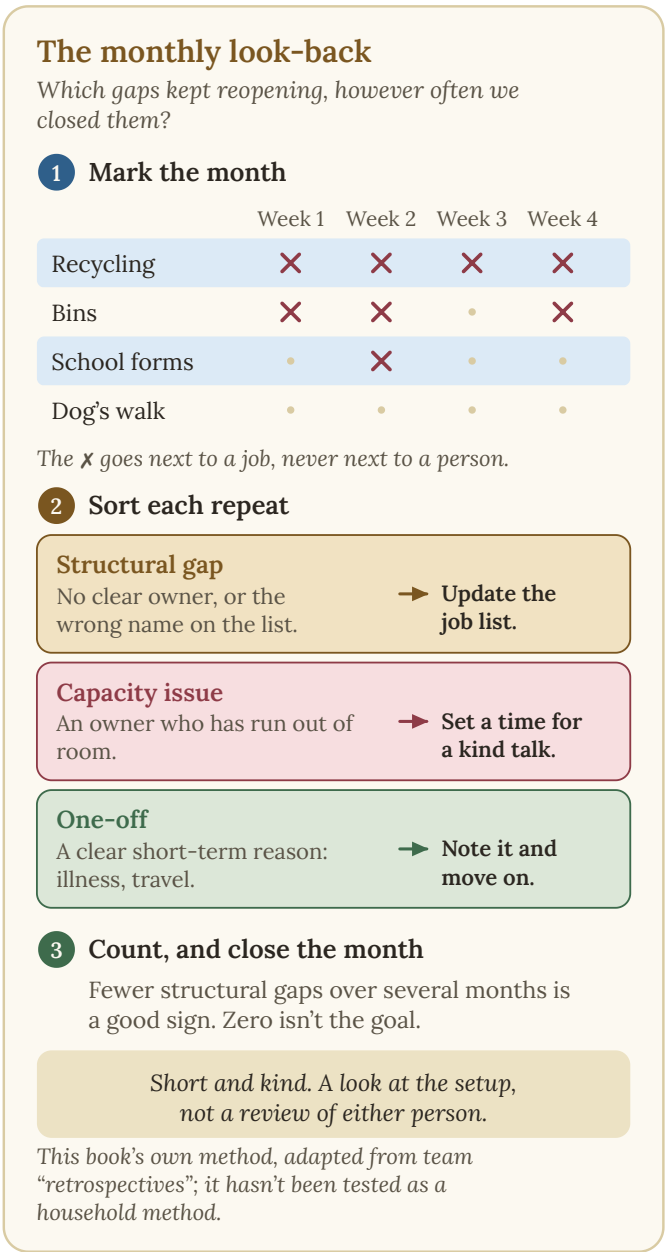



FIGURE 12 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

**What keeps coming back?**

*Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home*

## What keeps coming back?

| Person A | Person B |
|---|---|
| *Ash* | *Robin* |
| **Person C** | **Month** |
| *Jules* | *September 2026* |

### Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

| Task | Week 1 | Week 2 | Week 3 | Week 4 | Times flagged |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Cat litter* | ✗ | ✗ | | ✗ | 3 |
| *Recycling out on Thursday* | | ✗ | ✗ | | 2 |
| *Book Jules's car service* | | | ✗ | | 1 |
| *Shared calendar kept up to date* | ✗ | ✗ | ✗ | ✗ | 4 |

### Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

| Task | Named owner on the job list? | Classification | Action |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Cat litter* | No | *Structural gap* | *Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight* |
| *Shared calendar kept up to date* | Yes | *Capacity issue* | *Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list* |
| *Recycling out on Thursday* | Yes | *One-off, no action* | *Two bank holidays moved the day* |

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

**Structural gaps found**

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

**Capacity issues found**

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

**One-offs**

1

**Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?**

| Job | Gets thanked | Only noticed when missed? | One way to notice it |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Keeping the calendar* | *Rarely* | *Yes* | *Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date* |
| *Topping up the cat food* | *Never* | *Yes* | *A note on the fridge* |

*A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.*

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04)

06

## Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working, and a single month can be a normal wobble. If it keeps going up, something bigger has changed and it's worth a talk. Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office, next to the fire-drill notice. In March four jobs had no clear owner. By June, one did, and they argue quite cheerfully about whose fault that one is.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The look-back has its own workpaper: a month of notes, one list, and an ✗ for each week a job slipped. It makes a pattern easy to see.

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

07

## Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news. It's also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going in quiet months and add one question, "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning?*", which is how a look-back guards against complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

The children have left home and nothing whatsoever is slipping. The look-back takes eleven minutes. At the end Dave says, quietly, looking at his tea, that they don't really talk at dinner any more. Jan had noticed it too, months ago, without knowing how to say it. No list would have shown it.

08

## It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet and what you'll try next month. After a month in hospital, Yusuf came home to a long list of what had slipped while he was away. His partner had been dreading showing it to him. He read it, and then he said thank you for the bits that hadn't slipped, which was most of them, and they set up the month ahead. That was all.

**A just culture**

Sidney Dekker argues for a just culture, one that separates honest mistakes from reckless ones, and points out that who draws that line matters as much as where it's drawn. At home, I'd draw it together, on a calm day.

**Dekker (2007)** · *Moderate: an influential book; the evidence is mainly case studies*



TIDBIT

Start the look-back with something that went well. It changes the temperature of the whole twenty minutes.

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

09

## Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well and talk about the job instead of the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins). If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and whoever paused names a time to come back. A mum and two teenagers hold their look-back over pizza on the last Friday. Each says one good thing first (the younger one's is always "the pizza"). One gap gets a new owner. It's over in fifteen minutes and nobody has stormed off, which in that house is a result.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 14

**Kitchen-table check-in: this week**

*Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together*

### Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)
*Linda and Jordan*

One thing that went well
*Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.*

One thing that felt heavy
*The bathroom, again. And Mum's back was bad all week.*

One small thing to try next week
*Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.*

Our next check-in
*Sunday after dinner*

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

**ON THE CARD**

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: this week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

*Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes and about twenty minutes. You go down the list together, and most weeks were fine. Two jobs keep coming up, the recycling and the call to the landlord about the window that won't shut. You give each of them a name, and the landlord one goes to whoever's least scared of the landlord. You finish your tea while it's still warm, which hasn't happened on a Sunday in months.*

## A look-back, three months in

Sam and Alex's bins slipped three weeks running because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After the trial swap they make it official, so Sam owns the bins and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, which keeps the hours even. The second month is clean. In the third, the grocery order slips twice, both times in a week when Alex's mum was in hospital, so

they mark it as a one-off and leave the list alone. What actually changes in month three is that Alex mentions, almost in passing, while stacking the plates, that he has stopped enjoying their Saturday mornings. No list had shown that. They agree to talk about it properly on Thursday, and Sam spends most of the week worrying about it.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

## Common mix-ups

This isn't where you settle who owes what. Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them. You only fix the setup going forward. A slipped job doesn't mean its owner failed, either, because the gap might be in the list, or in the owner's capacity, or in one strange week. And you can't skip the weekly notes and just do this. The look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.

**A note on safety:** These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If looking back together ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A look-back is something you both choose. If one person demands logs of the other's every hour, checks their phone without agreement, or uses the ✗ marks to punish, that is control, not a look-back, and it is not your fault. See Not safe at home? and normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).

## Starting out: before you move in

If you are new together and about to share a home, the tools work best now, before habits set, at about one step a week. In the first week, each of you writes down the rulebook from the home you grew up in

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) and then you swap, with curiosity. In the second, talk about money, starting with your money stories and moving on to the split (Chapter IV, page 92). In the third, write your first job list, with one owner per job and the thinking jobs included (One owner per job, spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03), and in the fourth, make a pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) on a calm day. In the fifth, each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Part Three, Chapter 10, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values). After the move, log one ordinary week once two weeks have passed, and do your first short look-back after four. None of it is a test. The point is that neither of you has to guess.

Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find that their families meant very different things by "tidy". They agree on the kitchen every night and the rest on Sunday, and on Tariq's mother never being told about the rest.

## Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it involves things that keep coming back, such as cancelled calls and the hard evenings after contact. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own. Some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't, and for those you can own the plan for the evening after. The child may love both the parent who can't look after them and you, so tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them. Explain an absent parent in short, true words that fit their age, always with the message that it isn't their fault. When the parent is your own grown-up child and things are hard between you, keep messages about the child short and civil for the child's sake, and leave the door open. Look after yourself too. Ask for respite, and find other kinship carers. In England and Wales, the charity Kinship (kinship.org.uk) can help.

Maureen, who is sixty-three, is raising her grandson Tyler, who is nine. Her look-back shows that his mum's Sunday call fell through three times this month. She can't fix that. So she plans those evenings instead, with hot chocolate and his football annual, and asks her brother to take Tyler

swimming on Sunday afternoons, so there's something to look forward to that doesn't depend on a phone ringing.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD
> "Mum loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

## More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists pages for each one.

- More than two partners (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Money together · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Kids grown and gone (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

## On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month kindly, more like a weather report than a scorecard. What filled your battery and what drained it? Which of your limits held and which slipped? Choose one small thing to keep and one to change. Rhiannon lives on her own after a divorce, and her look-back showed the same ✗ three weeks running. She'd skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails, every week, telling herself it was

just this once. So she moved the emails to Friday morning, and kept the swim (see On my own).

To begin, put a relaxed twenty-minute date in the calendar once a month and keep your weekly notes somewhere you can both find them. At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well, and end by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so that over the next few months you can see whether the number is falling. What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back) is the workpaper for that conversation.

That's the end of Part Two. The book goes on in Part Three: Understanding people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings), chapters on how people work, for anyone. To put Parts One and Two into practice first, try the six-week program (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01): six gentle weeks, with one chapter and one small tool each week.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Weekly check-ins miss patterns.
- ✓ Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.
- ✓ Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.
- ✓ Look back even when nothing is slipping.
- ✓ Keep it short and kind.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Part One · Next · Who you are becoming**
*The same kind look, on your own*
read online

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*Why problems come back, and how habits stick*
read online

**Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?**
*The setup score the look-back feeds*
page 45

**Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt**
*Repairing what the look-back finds*
read online

PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 6: make it last**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

**What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back

# Workpapers and tools in this book

*Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.*

## Workpapers mentioned in this book

*Pages to fill in, on your own or together.*

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01
In: The work nobody sees (page 18), Is the split working? (page 45), The monthly look-back (page 96)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Is the split working? (page 45), Full tanks and different angles (page 64), The monthly look-back (page 96)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Is the split working? (page 45), Two kinds of fair (page 79), The monthly look-back (page 96)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04
In: The monthly look-back (page 96)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Why we get out of tune (page 32), Two kinds of fair (page 79)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 64)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Why we get out of tune (page 32)

## Tools mentioned in this book

*Interactive helpers to use on the site.*

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder
In: Why we get out of tune (page 32), Full tanks and different angles (page 64)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins
In: The monthly look-back (page 96)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins`
In: Two kinds of fair (page 79)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 64)

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration`
In: Why we get out of tune (page 32)

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: The work nobody sees (page 18)

TOOL **Who does what? Count the hours and bills** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: Is the split working? (page 45), Two kinds of fair (page 79)

TOOL **My weather today** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 64)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`
In: Why we get out of tune (page 32), Full tanks and different angles (page 64)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`
In: Is the split working? (page 45), Full tanks and different angles (page 64), Two kinds of fair (page 79), The monthly look-back (page 96)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 64), Two kinds of fair (page 79), The monthly look-back (page 96)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`
In: Is the split working? (page 45)

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working`
In: Is the split working? (page 45)

# How the numbers work

*Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.*

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them**: if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

## The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III, page **64**, scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

**Two or more of you:** each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

**Coming back after a pause** (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named

time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

### My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

| WHAT YOU PICKED | ADDS |
|---|---|
| The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in | 0, 26, 34 |
| The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6) | 0, 10, 20 |
| Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6) | 0, 2, 10, 18 |
| People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4) | 0, 3, 9, 14 |
| Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on) | 4 each, up to 14 |
| What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on) | 3 each, up to 10 |

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now (online), picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

### Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

**Two people.** Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷ 100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the stress

tank sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Part Two, Chapter II, page 45). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

**Three or more people, or an agreed split.** The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split you
agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter II, page 45): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167; most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667; balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

## Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: 9 ÷ 12 = 0.75.

**Who carries more of the list.** A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷ 0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of all
the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but 5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71% of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

**Who's carrying more right now.** Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the example in the Preface, page **18**, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

## The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average tank score) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the tank score. The tank is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − tank. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the "Who does what?" page says "holding"); 0.40 up to 0.70 as

needs a look ("drifting"); below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter II, page 45): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own tank scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

**The shortfall** is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067; ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088; tank 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the tank, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a tank score lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

**The overall score** adds a fourth part, retuning: of the moments that landed badly this week, how many you retuned before answering.

```
overall = balance × 0.35 + ownership × 0.30 + (1 − tank) × 0.20 +
retuning × 0.15
(no rough moments this week: leave retuning out, and divide the first
three parts by 0.85)
```

In Chapter II's first worked example (balance 0.60, ownership 0.80, an average tank score of 0.40, and 3 of 5 rough moments retuned): `0.21 + 0.24 + 0.12 + 0.09 = 0.66`.

## The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the stress tank, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership, tank),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller didn't
shift
```

**One next step:** a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's tank at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

**Hours to change hands over the month:** for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks: hours 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12; jobs with an owner 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12; Rosemary's tank 0.45, 0.50, 0.40, 0.35 and Ken's 0.30 every week; rescues 3, 2, 1, 1.

| PART | START (WEEKS 1–2) | END (WEEKS 3–4) | CHANGE | READS AS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Balance | (0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79 | (0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96 | +0.17 | Better |
| Ownership | 0.75 | 0.92 | +0.17 | Better |
| Average tank score | 0.39 | 0.34 | −0.05 | About the same |
| Rosemary's own tank | 0.48 | 0.38 | −0.10 | Lighter |
| Rescues a week | 2.5 | 1 | −1.5 | Fewer |

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

## On your own: is your week sustainable?

The “Who does what?” page’s “just me” view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book’s own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn’t be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a “How is this worked out?” note.

# Blank worksheets

*Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them in by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.*

# Who did what

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01.html

Write down what actually happened this week, before anyone starts remembering it as a story. Write down only what you did or saw yourself; never fill in someone else's side for them.

Person A _____ Person B _____

Week beginning _____

### Part A: Who did what, this week

One row for each task noticed or done, including the invisible ones: remembering, planning, booking, forms. Time spent only thinking, noticing or planning counts too: log it as "Thinking and planning".

| Day | Task noticed or done | Who did it | Minutes (rough) | How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |

### This week's totals

Person A: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Person B: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Workload balance score: 1 − (A% − B%, ignoring any minus sign) ÷ 100 = _____

Part B (optional), Kind ways to say no: say why the request is fair, say honestly what you have left, and offer something instead.

Describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it. How the score works: "How the numbers work", at the back.

# How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

### The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That fills the tank; it isn't a mood.

| | Not at all | | | | Very true |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sleep debt (less rested than usual) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Recent unresolved conflict (any source) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain) | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
| Time pressure today specifically | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |

### How full is your stress tank?

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Tank: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a fuller tank (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

### Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

**Anything you want to name before talking**

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

# One owner per job

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03.html

Every regular job gets one owner, the person who does it and sees it through. If you like, add a helper or backup who pitches in, notices if it slips, or covers it on a bad week. List the invisible jobs too: forms, gifts, renewals, planning, appointments.

Date of this list

The split you agreed (optional)

### Who owns each job

| Job | How often | Owner | Helper or backup (optional) | Size (optional) | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, As needed, Ongoing. Size: Small, Medium, Big.

### Does every job have an owner?

Jobs with an owner: _____ of _____ = _____ out of 1.00

### Changes to the list (optional)

| Date | What changed | Who |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |

### Where we've landed

Agreeing means everyone has read this version and knows who owns what. It doesn't mean every job feels perfectly fair, only that ownership is clear.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

# What keeps coming back?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04.html

A monthly look-back, done together, across four weeks of Who did what and One owner per job. It looks for the tasks that keep slipping. You're looking for where the setup needs a fix. Nobody is adding up what anyone owes.

Month

### Part A: Gather the month's notes

List every task that was noticed but not done, or done only after being raised more than once. Mark an ✗ for each week it came up.

| Task | Week 1 | Week 2 | Week 3 | Week 4 | Times flagged |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

### Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more. A **structural gap** has no clear owner (fix One owner per job now). A **capacity issue** has an owner who can't keep up (set a time for an honest conversation). A **one-off** has a temporary cause (note it and move on).

| Task | Named owner on the job list? (Yes / No) | Classification | Action |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

### Part C: Wrap up the audit

Structural gaps found

Capacity issues found

One-offs

### Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

| Job | Gets thanked (Often / Sometimes / Rarely / Never) | Only noticed when missed? (Yes / No) | One way to notice it |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

Not a bill for the past, and not a performance review. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

# Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

### Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

**Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)**

**What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The bins went out late on Tuesday."**

**What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.**

**What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.**

### Before you react: four quick checks

| Check | Circle one |
|---|---|
| Is this about a specific, nameable task or event? | Yes · No |
| Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot? | Yes · No · Not sure |
| Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said? | Yes · No |
| Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation? | Their words · A past pattern |

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keeps it honest.

# The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| | |
| | |
| | |

### Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed flat into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

### Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at quarter past."

_____

### Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

**Part B, in the moment:** say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

### Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your stress tank score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50 go back; 0.50 to 0.59 another round; 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

| Time | What I did | How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough) | Stress tank before (0–1) | Stress tank after (0–1) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |
| | | | | |
| | | | | |

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

### Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

# The 90-second daily check-in

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13.html

Each person answers each prompt in one sentence, about their own day, and fills in only their own rows. No debating, no solving, no arguing back. Anything that needs a real discussion waits for the weekly catch-up.

Week beginning

### Each day

| Day | Person | Stress tank (Light / Medium / High) | One thing I appreciated today | One small thing that didn't feel great | One thing that would help tomorrow |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | | |
| Mon | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |

### The weekly catch-up (optional)

Skim the week for anything that came up more than twice, and move it to the right worksheet.

| Sore spot that keeps coming up | Times this week | Move to (One owner per job / Say it so it lands / Keep watching) |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |

### Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

# Same moment, different speeds

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-12.html

For a few moments that come round often, each person marks how fast they want to move, how much they want to talk, and how urgent it feels. Each person fills in only their own rows, ideally before looking at the other's. There are no right answers.

Date

### Part A: Each person's speed

Speed: right away · within the hour · later the same day · after a night's sleep. Talk: quiet time first · a few words, then act · talk it all through. Urgency: low · medium · high.

| Moment | Person | Speed | Talk | Urgency | What helps me (optional) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A plan changes at the last minute | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| A bill, letter or form needs dealing with | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| Something breaks or goes wrong at home | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| One of us is upset about something | | | | | |
| | | | | | |
| Deciding what to do with free time | | | | | |
| | | | | | |

### Part B: Where your speeds differ

For each moment, count how many steps apart your answers are on each list. Start with the biggest gap: a difference in pace, not in how much anyone cares.

### Part C: One small agreement

| Moment | What we'll try | Try it until |
|---|---|---|
| | | |
| | | |

### Where we've landed

Agreeing means you have both seen the gaps and will try the agreement. It doesn't mean either of you has to change speed for good.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Not a compatibility test and not a diagnosis. Run it again every few months, or after a big change.

# Is it us, or is it everything else?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-14.html

A one-week log that keeps two things apart: pressure from outside (money, work, health, sleep, family) and friction that really starts between you. A line or two each evening, each person about their own day. Write what happened, not who was wrong.

Week beginning

### Part A: Each evening

| Day | Person | Outside pressure today (None / A little / A lot) | Where it came from | A tense moment between us (if any) | Looking back, it was mostly (Outside pressure / Between us / Some of both / Not sure yet) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | | |
| Mon | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Tue | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Wed | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Thu | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Fri | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sat | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |
| Sun | | | | | |

### Part B: The week at a glance

Tense moments on heavy days: _____ of _____

### Part C: What got blamed on the wrong thing?

| The moment | What it seemed to be about | What was really going on | What would help next time |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |

### Part D: One plan for the pressure

The pressure we're facing right now

How we'll flag a heavy day

What we'll go easy on until it passes

One bit of outside help we could ask for (optional)

Outside pressure explains a hard day. It doesn't excuse unkindness, and it doesn't make what anyone felt less real.

# Keep your little rituals alive

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15.html

Every three months or so, a short look at the small shared habits that keep you close: the morning coffee, the Sunday walk, the birthday breakfast. Nobody is to blame for one that lapsed.

Date

### Part A: Our rituals, big and small

How it's doing: Alive (still happening, still means something) · Fading (on autopilot or less often) · Stopped · New idea. How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Yearly, Now and then.

| Ritual or habit | How often | How it's doing | What it gives us, or what got in the way |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |
| | | | |

### Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual

The smallest version that still counts

The first time: when, and who will suggest it

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)

### Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual

What it gave us

### Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

A ritual is something you would both miss, not a test of love. Look at this sheet again in about three months.

# Words used in this book

*The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.*

### Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

### Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

*For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your stress tank is nearly full and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.*

### Calm-down plan

Your calm-down plan (once called the Calm-Down Kit) is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

*For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.*

### Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

*For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.*

### Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

*For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"*

### Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

*For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.*

### Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

*For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.*

### Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

*For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"*

### Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

*For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.*

### Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

### Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

### The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

### Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book works the same way: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

### The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

*For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.*

### Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

### My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

*For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.*

### Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

*For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.*

### Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

### Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

*For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.*

### Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

*For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."*

### Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

### Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

*For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.*

### Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

### Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

*For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.*

### Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

*For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.*

### Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

*For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.*

### Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

*For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.*

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# Research notes

*The 83 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.*

## Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study", "linked with", "didn't replicate". Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

**Correlational ("linked with")**
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

**Experiment**
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

**Meta-analysis**
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

**Replication**
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

**Effect size**
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

**Who was studied**
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

**Self-report**
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

**How the book labels things:** a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PREFACE TO PART TWO

## The work nobody sees


**Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999).** *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 61(1), 199–212. Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labour.
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clarkrelationshiplab.yale.edu

**Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992).** *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
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**Daminger, A. (2019).** *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**di Leonardo, M. (1987).** *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
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**Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009).** *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
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**Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989).** *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com

**Kurdek, L. A. (2007).** *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Journal of Family Issues, 28(1), 132–148. Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
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**Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979).** *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

**Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., Brown, G. L., Cannon, E. A., Mangelsdorf, S. C., & Sokolowski, M. S. (2008).** *Maternal gatekeeping, coparenting quality, and fathering behavior in families with infants.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(3), 389–398. In 97 couples with infants, fathers were more involved in day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them (gate-opening); when mothers were highly critical (gate-closing), fathers' own beliefs about involvement mattered less.
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## Why we get out of tune

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routledge.com

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PART TWO · CHAPTER II

## Is the split working?

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**Daminger, A. (2019).** *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
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**Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009).** *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
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rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

**Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989).** *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
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bls.gov/tus

**Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015).** *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 77(3), 662–679. Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
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PART TWO · CHAPTER III

## Full tanks and different angles

**Amato, P. R. (2001).** *Children of divorce in the 1990s: An update of the Amato and Keith (1991) meta-analysis.* Journal of Family Psychology, 15(3), 355–370. Updated a meta-analysis comparing children of divorced and continuously married parents; differences in wellbeing were small on average and persisted in studies from the 1990s.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.15.3.355

**Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983).** *A global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

**Emery, R. E. (1982).** *Interparental conflict and the children of discord and divorce.* Psychological Bulletin, 92(2), 310–330. Reviewed evidence that conflict between parents, in married and divorced families, is linked to children's problems, and that the amount and type of conflict matter.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.92.2.310

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Hetherington, E. M., & Kelly, J. (2002).** *For Better or For Worse: Divorce Reconsidered.* W. W. Norton. Drawing on long-term studies of about 1,400 families, argues that most children of divorce and remarriage turn out reasonably well, with outcomes varying widely.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393324136-for-better-or-for-worse

**Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971).** *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

**Maccoby, E. E., & Mnookin, R. H. (1992).** *Dividing the Child: Social and Legal Dilemmas of Custody.* Harvard University Press. Following more than a thousand separating families for three years, described three patterns of co-parenting among families where children spent time in both homes: cooperative, conflicted and disengaged; most parents avoided legal battles but many found it hard to cooperate.
hls.harvard.edu

**Neff, K. D. (2003).** *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

**Neff, L. A., & Karney, B. R. (2009).** *Stress and reactivity to daily relationship experiences: How stress hinders adaptive processes in marriage.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 97(3), 435–450. Spouses under more stress outside the relationship reacted more strongly to everyday negative experiences within it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015663

**Papernow, P. L. (2013).** *Surviving and Thriving in Stepfamily Relationships: What Works and What Doesn't.* Routledge. Describes "stepfamily architecture" and five common challenges it creates, drawing on research and clinical experience; closeness between stepfamily members typically builds slowly.
routledge.com

**Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996).** *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

## Two kinds of fair

**Adams, J. S. (1965).** *Inequity in social exchange.* In L. Berkowitz (Ed.), Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, Vol. 2, pp. 267–299. Academic Press. Founding statement of equity theory: people compare the ratio of what they put in to what they get out with someone else's, and feel tension when the ratios differ.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60108-2

**Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999).** *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 61(1), 199–212. Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labour.
doi.org/10.2307/353894

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**Deming, W. E. (1986).** *Out of the Crisis.* MIT Press (Center for Advanced Engineering Study), Cambridge, MA. Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

**Deutsch, M. (1975).** *Equity, equality, and need: What determines which value will be used as the basis of distributive justice?* Journal of Social Issues, 31(3), 137–149. Argued that equity is only one of several justice principles, alongside equality and need, and proposed when groups favour each: equality in cooperative relationships, equity in economic ones, need in caring ones.
data.gesis.org/gesiskg/resource/zis-Deutsch1975Equity

**Dew, J., Britt, S., & Huston, S. (2012).** *Examining the relationship between financial issues and divorce.* Family Relations, 61(4), 615–628. In US national survey data on about 4,500 couples, financial disagreements were the strongest of the disagreement types in predicting later divorce, for both wives and husbands.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2012.00715.x

**Gottman, J. M. (1994).** *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

**Klontz, B., Britt, S. L., Mentzer, J., & Klontz, T. (2011).** *Money beliefs and financial behaviors: Development of the Klontz Money Script Inventory.* Journal of Financial Therapy, 2(1), 1–22. In 422 respondents, beliefs about money clustered into four "money scripts" (money avoidance, money worship, money status and money vigilance), several of which were linked with income and net worth.
doi.org/10.4148/jft.v2i1.451

**Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005).** *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

**Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007).** *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

**Papp, L. M., Cummings, E. M., & Goeke-Morey, M. C. (2009).** *For richer, for poorer: Money as a topic of marital conflict in the home.* Family Relations, 58(1), 91–103. In home diary records of marital conflict, money was not the most frequent topic, but money conflicts were more pervasive, problematic and recurrent than other conflicts and more likely to stay unresolved.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2008.00537.x

**Rick, S. I., Small, D. A., & Finkel, E. J. (2011).** *Fatal (fiscal) attraction: Spendthrifts and tightwads in marriage.* Journal of Marketing Research, 48(2), 228–237. Tightwads and spendthrifts tend to marry each other; the bigger the difference within a couple, the more conflict over money, which in turn predicts lower marital wellbeing.
doi.org/10.1509/jmkr.48.2.228

**Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979).** *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

**Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., Brown, G. L., Cannon, E. A., Mangelsdorf, S. C., & Sokolowski, M. S. (2008).** *Maternal gatekeeping, coparenting quality, and fathering behavior in families with infants.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(3), 389–398. In 97 couples with infants, fathers were more involved in day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them (gate-opening); when mothers were highly critical (gate-closing), fathers' own beliefs about involvement mattered less.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

**Stone, D., Patton, B., & Heen, S. (1999).** *Difficult Conversations: How to Discuss What Matters Most.* Viking (New York); 10th-anniversary edition, Penguin 2010. A practitioner book from the Harvard Negotiation Project describing three conversations inside every hard conversation (what happened, feelings, identity) and the gap between intent and impact.
penguinrandomhouse.com

**Taylor, M. J., McNicholas, C., Nicolay, C., Darzi, A., Bell, D., & Reed, J. E. (2014).** *Systematic review of the application of the plan–do–study–act method to improve quality in healthcare.* BMJ Quality & Safety, 23(4), 290–298. Of 73 healthcare articles reporting the use of plan–do–study–act cycles, most did not report key features of the method, such as iterative cycles, small tests of change and real-time data.
doi.org/10.1136/bmjqs-2013-001862

**Thibaut, J., & Walker, L. (1975).** *Procedural Justice: A Psychological Analysis.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Founded procedural-justice research: people's judgments of whether a decision process is fair (especially having a voice) shape how satisfied they are with the outcome.
law.virginia.edu/node/127096

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

## The monthly look-back

**Boss, P. (1999).** *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Harvard University Press. Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**Dekker, S. (2007).** *Just Culture: Balancing Safety and Accountability.* Ashgate (2nd ed. 2012). Argues for a "just culture" that separates honest mistakes from reckless behaviour, and that who draws the line matters as much as where it is drawn.
relbib.de/Record/1613173431

**Deming, W. E. (1986).** *Out of the Crisis.* MIT Press (Center for Advanced Engineering Study), Cambridge, MA. Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
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**Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975).** *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* Paper presented at the Conference in Monetary Economics, Sydney, July 1975; published in Papers in Monetary Economics, Vol. I (Reserve Bank of Australia, 1976); reprinted in Goodhart, Monetary Theory and Practice (Macmillan, 1984). The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

**Hayslip, B., Jr., & Kaminski, P. L. (2005).** *Grandparents raising their grandchildren: A review of the literature and suggestions for practice.* The Gerontologist, 45(2), 262–269. Reviewed research on custodial grandparents: the costs and benefits of raising a grandchild, how varied these families are, their need for social support, parenting, and help at several levels.
doi.org/10.1093/geront/45.2.262

**Pillemer, K. (2020).** *Fault Lines: Fractured Families and How to Mend Them.* Avery (Penguin Random House). Draws on the Cornell Reconciliation Project, including a national survey on estrangement and interviews, to show family estrangement is more common than people assume and that some people reconcile.
search.worldcat.org/oclc/1145305518

**Reason, J. (1990).** *Human Error.* Cambridge University Press. A theory of human error that sorts slips, lapses and mistakes, and introduced the layered-defences thinking behind the "Swiss cheese" model of accidents.
doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781139062367

**Reason, J. (1997).** *Managing the Risks of Organizational Accidents.* Ashgate (now Routledge). Describes how organisational accidents arise from latent conditions combining with front-line errors, and sets out ideas for a safety and "just" culture.
routledge.com

**Strathern, M. (1997).** *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* European Review, 5(3), 305–321. Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org

**Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1973).** *Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability.* Cognitive Psychology, 5(2), 207–232. People judge how common something is by how easily examples come to mind. That usually works, but vivid or recent examples make some things seem more common than they are.
apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA045770.pdf

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*Key ideas and the pages where the book talks about them. Chapter names are in the contents.*


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